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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' talking to media persons at Tribhuvan International Airport upon his arrival in Kathmandu on Sunday after attending the 19th summit of Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) held in Kampala, Uganda.

NAM remains relevant even today: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 21

> Although there are some doubts about the relevance of the Movement, it has a major role in the current world with problems such as inequality, neo-colonialism, geopolitical conflicts, and poverty.

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the relevancy of the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) has not diminished even in the present world order.

"To make the world system just and equitable, and to guarantee freedom, independence and geographical integrity to all countries, the importance of the non-aligned movement remains the same as it was in the past for all communities across the world in order to achieve prosperity and live a happy life," he said while speaking with the media at the Tribhuvan International Airport on Sunday upon his return from the 19th Summit of the NAM held in Kampala of Uganda.

The NAM was developed as the third strand in favour of freedom, independence and economic development in the aftermath of the Second World War when the world was divided into two political camps, he noted.

"Although there are some doubts about the relevance of the Movement, it has a major role in the current world with problems such as inequality, neo-colonialism, geopolitical conflicts, and poverty," said PM Prachanda.

Meanwhile, speaking at the closing ceremony of the summit, UN Secretary-General António Guterres appreciated the non-aligned countries' great contribution to making the world order fair, inclusive and equitable, and said that its relevance has increased even more in the current world environment.

PM Prachanda's delegation to the NAM Summit included Foreign Minister NP Saud, Prime Minister's Foreign Affairs Adviser Dr. Rupak Sapkota, Foreign Secretary Sewa Lamsal, Permanent Representative of Nepal to the United Nations, and other officials of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

Nepal is one of the founding countries of the NAM and it has participated in the Bandung Conference in 1955 when the Asia-Africa Conference passed the 10-point principles that laid the foundation of the Movement.

Since its inception, Nepal has been represented at the highest level in all the summits of the Movement and presented its independent point of view. "Non-alignment and its principles remain as the basic principles of Nepal's foreign policy. Based on this, despite the complex situations internationally, we have adopted an independent foreign policy with an organic approach in all cases," said PM Prachanda.

In his address to the NAM Summit, he recalled that the leaders of Asia and Africa presented the basic values of conducting international relations through the Bandung Conference in the atmosphere of the uneasy Cold War between the two superpowers about seven decades ago, and emphasized that the NAM has played an important role in enhancing the political freedom of many countries, ending colonialism and protecting sovereignty.

"Likewise, the NAM is a platform for deepening mutual cooperation. Through this, I emphasized that efforts should be made to achieve global prosperity by enhancing mutual cooperation and understanding," he said.

Noting that the principles of the Movement and its values and beliefs are important for Nepal, PM Prachanda clarified that its observance is a guide to achieving peace, harmony and a prosperous world, as well as being a basic principle of foreign policy. "I said that this Movement has contributed to increase the respect and reputation at the international level in order to enhance mutual harmony, cooperation and collaboration between us," he said.

Stating that the economic revival has not been able to pick up desired speed in the post-COVID scenario, the Prime Minister expressed his concern to the growing geo-political polarisation and fighting and climate change that are causing more damage to small and developing countries.

"Even though Nepal itself is in the process of being upgraded from a least developed country, it is faced with multifaceted challenges. From the perspective that least developed countries need strong support and cooperation from development partners, I have strongly raised the issue that the NAM should emphasize the achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals, the Paris Agreement and other internationally agreed development goals in time to achieve the economic development and prosperity of the developing countries of the world," he said.

According to the PM, he emphasized that the world economic and financial structure should be reformed in order to ensure the necessary financial resources for the economic progress of developing countries, and the NAM should play a leading role in reforming the international trade structure, and the United Nations, so as to secure the interests of developing countries.

"Developed countries must meet the financial needs of developing countries. By ensuring everyone's access to and participation in international trade, even less developed countries should be able to realize its benefits,"

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10,159 TEMPORARY SHELTERS BUILT IN JAJARKOT

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Jajarkot, Jan. 21

Two and half months after the November 3 earthquake, 10,159 temporary shelters have been constructed in Jajarkot.

A total budget of Rs. 1.3 billion has been disbursed from the District Disaster Management Fund till Friday.

Of the total 42,524 beneficiaries in the district, 28,038 beneficiaries have signed an agreement for the first instalment amount to construct temporary housing, and only 27,091 beneficiaries have received the first instalment amount as of Friday.

Information Officer and Administrative Officer of the District Administration Office, Harish Chandra Sharma, said the local government had released an amount of Rs. 677 million for temporary housing. Of the total constructed housing, 9,637 temporary shelters were constructed in the government grant and 522 were made in support of NGOs and other partner agencies, said Sharma.

The District Disaster Management Fund has deposited Rs. 136 million in the fund of the Bheri Municipality for a total of 6,635 beneficiaries. Of them, 4,652 have received their first tranche.

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Police adjustment process to begin immediately: DPM Shrestha

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Sarlahi, Jan. 21

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha has said that the federal police adjustment process in the provinces will be taken into the implementation phase soon.

Inaugurating the newly constructed prison office in Malangwa of Sarlahi on Sunday, DPM Shrestha said that there would be no delay in the work of police adjustment according to the spirit of federalism.

"After going to federalism, the adjustment of the police must be done, for this reason, the Nepal Police and Province Police (Operation, Supervision, and Coordination) Act, 2020, and Police Personnel Act, 2020 have also been passed," DPM Shrestha said.

"Earlier, the government had its thought that the adjustment process would be forwarded only after amending these two Acts, but now, the Ministry has not any such thoughts as such to take the process ahead at the earliest possible," DPM Shrestha said.

He claimed that the government was working to give justice to the victims in connection with loan sharks (unfair transactions), which has been a serious problem in the Tarai.

He said that the police and administration would not accept interference and pressure from anyone in the work of giving justice to the victims of loan sharks. The Ministry is receiving complaints that some powerful people and administration officials have been backing up loan-shark perpetrators to settle the issue, he said.

If there is no reconciliation, the culprits will be identified and action will be taken, he said.

DPM Shrestha said that if the creditor had invested the money, such an amount would be returned with fair interest as per the law.

He mentioned that the government had already made some conclusions to solve the problem of cooperatives and finance across the country and had proceeded accordingly.

He said that the police and administration had been strictly instructed not to cause any kind of trouble while bringing raw materials for domestic purposes and consumption from the Indian market.

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PHOTO: RSS

DPM Narayan Kaji Shrestha addressing the inaugural function of newly constructed prison office in Malangwa of Sarlahi district on Sunday.

Freezing cold adds to woes of landslide victims

BY MEENA KANDEL
Kawasoti, Jan. 21

Cold has increased in East Nawalparasi for the past few days. With thick fog in the morning, the cold waves continue the whole day, making life difficult for landslide victims, children, senior citizens and the poor. The landslide victims find it difficult to fight the cold living in temporary shelters.

The movement of the general people in the market has decreased with the falling temperature. The roads, alleys and junctions look deserted, especially in morning and evening times.

More than 133 landslide victims from 18 households of Baghakhor in Hupsekot Rural Municipality-5 in the district have been forced to stay under tents for the last two years.

Khagisara Rana Magar, a landslide victim, said that it was difficult to survive in the winter days of January and February.

She further said, "After being displaced by the landslide we get worried at the arrival of winter, as we still don't have safe houses. The rainfall during winter makes our life very difficult."

Since their displacement after a landslide hit their settlement on July 21, 2021, the landslide victims have not been sure about their new permanent settlement. They have been living a miserable life in makeshifts since then. The two-room shelter made of blocks and tin and a single tent has been a shelter for each family of the victims for over two and half years.

One of the landslide victims, Khem Bahadur Somi Magar, said that the elderly and children were facing health problems due to cold while others had to remain busy managing two meals a day by working as daily wage earners.

Dilmaya Somai, who has been living in one of the temporary shelters, said "Many families are struggling to live in a small room." Because of the shivering cold, many of the victims have been unable to go to work these days.

Before the landslide, each of the families had one to three bighas of land to cultivate, but after the landslide, the locals lost both their houses and land.

Laxmi Devi Pandey, the chairperson of Hupsekot Rural Municipality, said that the Rural Municipality was taking initiatives for the permanent solution to the problems faced by the landslide victims with support from the federal and provincial governments.

Taudaha sees a tumble in winter water fowls

BY INDIRA ARYAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 21

The water bird census in Kathmandu has revealed a concerning trend this year, with a noticeable decline in the number of birds found in and around Taudaha, Bagmati, and Manohara.

Dr. Hem Sagar Baral, a prominent ornithologist, has issued a warning that Taudaha, the renowned pond where birds from as far as Siberia in Africa used to migrate during winter, may be devoid of any birds within a few years.

"The situation in Taudaha is of serious concern, where the once thriving population of 400 to 500 individuals across different species has now dwindled to a mere 39 individuals. Continuing bird counts in the area seems futile, so we have decided not to conduct bird counting in the Taudaha area from next year," he added.

Dr. Baral informed that only three species of duck families – tufted duck, common teal, and gadwall – along with two other species of birds, including the great cormorant and black-crowned night heron, were recorded in the Taudaha area.

The situation in Bagmati and Manohara is also disheartening. Only 127 individuals were recorded in Bagmati, including the grey-headed lapwing and long-billed plover. Only one individual of the long-billed plover was recorded in Bagmati. In Manohara, only 333 individuals were observed, with 102 individuals of cattle egret recorded in the area.



"Birdwatchers were actively involved in the counting, working diligently from 8:30 am to 5:00 pm, covering a longer distance compared to previous years. However, the results did not yield the expected excitement," he said.

The decline in the winter bird population within the Kathmandu Valley is a consequence of the swift and unplanned urbanization, haphazard development, and encroachment upon rivers and wetlands.

The census results have not been received from across the country, and in some areas, the count is being repeated due to persistent cloud cover throughout the day. The enumeration was reiterated at Fewa Lake last Saturday, and a similar repetition is scheduled for Jagdishpur Lake very soon due to unsatisfactory results attributed to cloud cover.

The results from other areas are also less satisfactory compared to previous years. Unlike last year when the skies were clear, enabling timely counting, this year, persistent clouds in the Tarai region have hampered the counting process.

It will take a few weeks for the detailed report of the count to be compiled, Dr. Baral said. Various organisations in different districts are collaborating on the 37th water bird census, led by Himalayan Nature this year. This census focuses on counting water-dependent species, including ducks, eagles, and other birds.

As snow blankets the northern part of Russia, Mongolia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and China in the northern hemisphere, birds from these regions migrate to seek food and warmth, contributing to the increased winter bird population in Nepal. Mainly belonging to the duck family, the migratory species include black-headed ducks, long-tailed ducks, malak ducks, Khoya ducks, nadun ducks, and others.

Counting these birds is relatively straightforward as water birds often gather in water bodies after foraging in fields. During the counting process, binoculars are used to ensure accurate identification, avoiding double counting of the same bird.

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Exports down by 7% in first six months

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 21

Nepal's imports and exports both have declined during the first six months of the current fiscal year 2023/24. According to trade statistics made public by the Department of Customs Sunday, the country's export has declined by 7.23 per cent while the import decreased by 3.09 per cent during the first six months of the current fiscal year compared to the same period of last fiscal year 2022/23.

Goods worth Rs. 74.96 billion have been exported during the review period of the current fiscal year while the trade volume was Rs. 80.80 billion in the same period of last fiscal year. The reduction in the export of major exportable goods, including soybean oil and palm oil, resulted in decline in the overall export during the review period.

The country has exported soybean oil only worth Rs. 415 million in the first six months of the current fiscal year while soybean oil worth Rs. 8 billion had been exported in the corresponding period last fiscal year. Similarly, palm oil worth Rs. 2.90 billion has been exported in the review period while it was worth Rs. 13.08 billion during the first six months of the last fiscal year.

The export of sunflower oil has also dropped to Rs. 148 million during the review period as compared to the same period last fiscal year. During the review period, tea and coffee worth Rs. 2.17 billion, yarn worth Rs. 5.6 billion, carpet worth Rs. 6 billion and cardamom worth Rs. 3.9 billion had been exported.

Similarly, ginger worth Rs. 942 million, yarchhagumba worth Rs. 584 million, fruits juice worth Rs. 3.8 billion and pickles worth Rs. 67 million have been exported during the six months of the current fiscal year.

Increased cement export

The export of cement and clinker has increased significantly during the review period as compared to the same period last fiscal year. The country exported cement and clinker worth Rs. 1.76 billion in the first six months of the current fiscal year.

The cement and clinker only worth Rs. 86 million had been exported during the first six months of the last fiscal year. During the review period, imports have decreased by 3.09 per cent during the review period of the current fiscal year. Goods worth Rs. 768.16 billion were imported in the review period.

The country imported goods worth Rs. 792.66 billion in the same period last



fiscal year. The crude palm oil worth Rs. 7.55 billion, crude soybean oil worth Rs. 7.8 billion and sunflower oil worth Rs. 7.78 billion have been imported during the review period.

In the first six months of the current fiscal year, petrol worth Rs. 33.19 billion, diesel worth Rs. 66.49 billion, aviation fuel worth Rs. 10.12 billion and liquefied petroleum gas worth Rs. 25.45 billion have been imported.

Similarly, the country has imported maize worth Rs. 6.63 billion, paddy and rice worth Rs. 10.14 billion and wheat worth Rs. 5 billion. During the review period as compared to last year, the import of electric vehicles has increased significantly. About 6,000 electric vehicles, including car, jeeps, vans, bus and trucks worth Rs. 14 billion have been imported during the review period.

Similarly, electric three-wheelers worth Rs. 510 million have been imported during the review period.

Trade deficit drops

Decline in both exports and imports have contributed to a fall in foreign trade during the review period. The country's foreign trade has decreased significantly during the first six months of the current fiscal year 2023/24.

According to the Department of Customs, foreign trade has decreased by 3.47 per cent to Rs. 843.13 billion during the first six months of the current fiscal year.

Owing to declines in export as well as import, there was some improvement in the overall trade deficit during the review period of the current fiscal year as compared to the same period last fiscal year.

The country faces a trade deficit of Rs. 693.19 billion. It is 2.62 per cent less than the same period last year. The country had faced a trade deficit of Rs. 711.85 billion during the first six months of the last fiscal year.

NUMBER OF TAXPAYERS UP IN KMC

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 21

The number of taxpayers has increased in recent time in the Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC). The number of taxpayers was 324 thousand and 120 last financial year and it has reached 343 thousand and 340 in the current financial year, said Dhruba Kafle, the Chief of KMC's Revenue Department.

According to Kafle, 35 thousand and 57 taxpayers have increased under the heading - 'rental taxpayers', 31 thousand and 916 have been added under the heading of business taxpayers and 52 thousand and 486 have added under the heading of property taxpayers.

The number of taxpayers has gone up in other tax headings as well. The metropolis' revenue collection has also significantly increased with the increase in the taxpayers. Kafle said that KMC has collected approximately Rs 5 billion in revenue until the half of the current financial year.

KMC has been collecting revenue under 36 various headings, including property, house rent, business, advertisement, entertainment, land and VAT.

Country's economy on track, former finance minister says

RSS
Sankhuwasabha, Jan. 21

Nepali Congress (NC) leader and former finance minister Gyanendra Bahadur Karki has said that the country's economy has already grasped new trail.

At a news conference organized by Press Union Sankhuwasabha chapter at Khandbari on Sunday, Karki claimed that the country's economy has returned to the previous speed. The former Finance Minister said that the current coalition government is working to bring the economy on track adding that the economy that suffered badly after the coronavirus outbreak is gradually returning to normal condition.

On a separate context, the NC leader said the MCC is a grant assistance received for Nepal and it should be completed in five years. "MCC will be proved as a cornerstone in Nepal's energy sector," he added. He also claimed that it would help contribute in reducing trade deficit and make the country prosperous.

Stating that the under-construction Arun-III project will contribute to the country's economy, Karki opined that the residents of Sankhuwasabha district should be the first beneficiary of the project. Likewise, he claimed that all the candidates of the ruling alliance will emerge victorious in the upcoming National Assembly (NA) elections.

Women farmers provided goods to build polyhouse

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dadeldhura, Jan. 21

After the women expressed their desire to grow vegetables, the Agriculture Knowledge Centre, Dadeldhura provided plastic along with watering cans, seeds and spray tanks for the construction of the polyhouse.

Yagya Raj Joshi, Director of Agriculture Directorate Doti, Khemraj Paneru and Head of Agriculture Knowledge Centre, Dadeldhura, handed over agricultural inputs to the women's group amidst a function at Matela village of Ruwakhola of Ganyapadhura Rural Municipality-1 on Saturday.

Paneru said that plastic required for 26 tunnels, 26 watering cans, seeding and one spray tank were provided to the Nirpal Farmers Group of Matela village for the construction of the polyhouse.

He said that after the women of the farming group expressed their desire to cultivate vegetables, the budget not in the plan was managed from other areas and agricultural materials were provided. He said that they have provided plastic and other materials after the women constructed the tunnel using wood and bamboo.

"It didn't happen just by expressing a desire. We told women to construct the tunnel themselves to see whether they work or not. We have provided plastic, seeds, and watering cans after they constructed the structure of tunnels. This will encourage the women here towards commercial vegetable farming," said Paneru.

Stating that 12-metre-long and 6-metre-wide plastic has been provided, Director of Agriculture Directorate Joshi said that if more than 150 plants of tomatoes are planted in one polyhouse, at least four quintals of tomatoes will be produced in one polyhouse.

He said that the source of income will also increase as farmers can sell surplus tomatoes after consuming them by themselves. "At least 3 to 5 kilograms of tomatoes are grown on one plant. Even if it is grown at this proportion, four quintals of tomatoes are produced from one polyhouse. Women can earn income by selling the tomatoes."

Tulasi Deuba, Chairman of Nirpal Farmers' Group, said that a family buys vegetables worth Rs. 20,000 yearly and that expenses for vegetables consumption of the farmers involved in this group will be cut back.

"We just received support for the construction of the polyhouse and other agricultural inputs. We are happy. Now, we will work hard to cultivate vegetables. Additional support is needed for us. We believe that the concerned agencies will support us," said Deuba. A river flows from above Matela village and there is an irrigation system.

Gyanu Seti Deuba, vice-chairman of the rural municipality, said that there is more potential for vegetable cultivation because it is not very cold and there is no drought. Earlier, they had constructed a polyhouse in Sahukharka area of Ward No. 1 from the rural municipality.

She said, now the agricultural knowledge centre has provided agricultural materials in Matela village. She said that if the farmers here cultivate vegetables commercially, the support from organsiations, including rural municipalities, will increase.

Zipline welcomes more tourists



PHOTO/TRN

RSS
Pyuthan, Jan. 21

A zipline service has been introduced at Mallarani in Pyuthan district to lure the adventurous tourists there and to promote the touristic value of the site.

For the development of zipline infrastructure, the Mallarani Tourism Investment Company invested Rs 10 million, Company's Chairman Iman Singh Bharati said. Local residents there had been organizing food festival and other promotional activities. The zipline has been developed at Dhairechaur community forest and Paleban community forest area at ward number 4 of the rural municipality under the eco-tourism development programme.

The total length of the zipline facility is 650 metres. The locals and stakeholders have expected surge in the number of visitors with the infrastructure. More than 200 persons can enjoy the zipline service in a day.

Mallarani area, which lies some two kilometres away from the district headquarters of Pyuthan, is a good destination for eco-tourism and is a point to view Mt. Dhaulagiri, Mt Machhapuchhre and other peaks.

In order to attract more domestic tourists, the Mallarani Rural Municipality is mulling construction of a children's park and had already successfully conducted a test flight of paragliding there. However, paragliding could not last long.

The area receives more domestic tourists during the time of New Year, Fagu Purnima, time of rhododendron blossoming season and other holidays as well, local residents shared.

US-CHINA MEETING ON FINANCIAL ISSUE CONCLUDES

AP
Bangkok, Jan. 20

US and Chinese officials have completed the third meeting of a working group established to cooperate on financial issues, in a step that continues the trend set by the two powers last November to ease tensions.

Officials from the U.S. Department of the Treasury met with counterparts in the People's Bank of China to discuss issues ranging from financial stability to countering money laundering. The delegation also met with Vice Premier He Lifeng while they were in China, according to a statement from the Treasury Department Friday.

The group also indicated that Treasury Secretary Janet Yellen would return to China for a visit at some point in the future. She was previously there in July. In November, Yellen met with He in San Francisco.

AMBUKHARENI JOINS SOCIAL SECURITY FUND

RSS
Damauli (Tanahun), Jan. 21

The Ambukhaireni Rural Municipality of Tanahun has joined the Social Security Fund. The rural municipality has joined the fund under the contribution-based social security scheme started by the federal government.

Executive Director of Social Security Fund Kabiraj Adhikari and Chief Administrative Officer of the Rural Municipality Bishnu Prasad Sharma signed an agreement towards that end at a program held on Saturday. Following the agreement, workers within the rural municipality will be included in the scheme.

The rural municipality will work to add the people working in the informal sector to the online system. The contribution amount to be deposited in the fund from the related workers will be done through the rural municipality. For workers in the industrial sector and working informally, the federal and provincial governments contribute to the 9.37 per cent to be deposited in the fund.

Tata plans to cut 2,800 steel jobs

AP
London, Jan. 20

Indian firm Tata Steel announced Friday it will close both blast furnaces at its plant in Port Talbot, Wales, eliminating 2,800 jobs, as part of plans to make its unprofitable U.K. operation leaner and greener. Tata plans to switch from coal-fired blast furnaces to electric arc furnaces, which emit less carbon — and need fewer workers — using a half-billion pound ($634 million) investment from the British government.

The company said it would "commence statutory consultation as part of its plan to transform and restructure its U.K. business." "This plan is intended to reverse more than a decade of losses and transition from the legacy blast furnaces to a more sustainable, green steel business," it said.

The company said it expects about 2,800 jobs will be eliminated, most in the next 18 months, with a further 300 at longer-term risk. The news is a major blow to Port Talbot, a town of about 35,000 people whose economy has been built on the steel industry since the early 1900s.

Unions have called for one blast furnace to remain open while the electric one is built, which would have meant fewer job cuts. They say Tata rejected their proposal. The Unite union said it would "use everything in its armory" to fight job losses, including potential strikes.

At its height in the 1960s, the Port Talbot steelworks employed around 20,000 people, before cheaper offerings from China and other countries hit production. More than 300,000 people worked in Britain's steel industry in 1971; by 2021 it was about 26,000.

The steel industry now accounts for 0.1 percent of the British economy and 2.4% of the country's greenhouse gas emissions, according to research by the House of Commons Library. Tata warned in 2022 that its U.K. operations were under threat unless it secured government funding to help it move to less carbon-intensive electric arc furnaces.

Last year the U.K. government gave Tata up to 500 million pounds ($634 million) to make the Port Talbot steelworks greener. The British government said the investment would "secure a sustainable and competitive future for the U.K. steel sector." Moving to electric furnaces would "transform the site and protect thousands of jobs, both in Port Talbot and throughout the supply chain," it said.

Desk: 1

Issued by Kavrepalanchok District Court

21 (twenty one) days Subpoena issued in the name of Mr. Nadeem Mohammad, aged approx. 28 years, the son of Mr. Jafar Ali, the grandson of Mr. Alla Basaya, the resident of Multan District, Jalalpur Pariwala-99, Islamabad, Pakistan.

Hereinafter, in the divorce case (080-CP-0364) between plaintiff Mrs. Maili Lama, the resident of Kavrepalanchok District, former Gothpani Rural Municipality, Ward No. 09, presently converted to Chaurideurali Rural Municipality, Ward No. 04 and defendant you, the Subpoena issued in your name from this Court has been process as disappeared thus according to the decision dated January 16, 2024 A.D. this notice of subpoena has been published again pursuant to section 105 (22) of the National Civil Procedure Code, 2017. Therefore, within 21 (twenty one) days of publishing this notice in the newspaper law please be present excluding journey days at this court in person or power of attorney along with the statement of defence along with the evidence. If unable to file statement of defence or power of attorney or law practitioner is not present, the case shall be judged according to law and your claim shall not be entertained in future.

Done this on Monday, January 22, 2024 A.D.

Blooming mustard lures visitors

BY AMRIT PRASAD PAUDEL
Myagdi, Jan. 21

With the mustard field in full bloom in Ratnechaur in Beni Municipality- 1 of Myagdi district, thousands of people are visiting these mesmerizing fields for leisure and photography.

Mustard seeds sown after harvesting paddy in November have bloomed into beautiful and vibrant yellow flowers, which has attracted many nearby people.

Ajay Milan Shrestha and Sirjana Shrestha of Beni Municipality-7, who reached Ratnechaur to participate in the 28th commemoration day programme of Om Bogati, the founding Chairman of Nepali Congress, were enthralled by the stunning mustard field and captured the scenery in their camera.

Similarly, people visiting Beni for different reasons stop by the mustard field at least once. A Nepali team including Dhanamaya KC who came to Pokhara from Japan also stopped by the field to take pictures.

A combination of green and yellow hues in the backdrop of snowcapped mountains makes Ratnechaur beautiful. But, after the construction of a pitched road in the middle of the mustard field in 2020, it caught the attention of many passengers traveling through the road.

Ganesh Bahadur Bogati, a local, said, "Ratnechaur has become viral because of the constructed road and social media. Its popularity suddenly rose after the road was built in an initiative of Bhupendra Thapa, the former member of the House of Representatives."

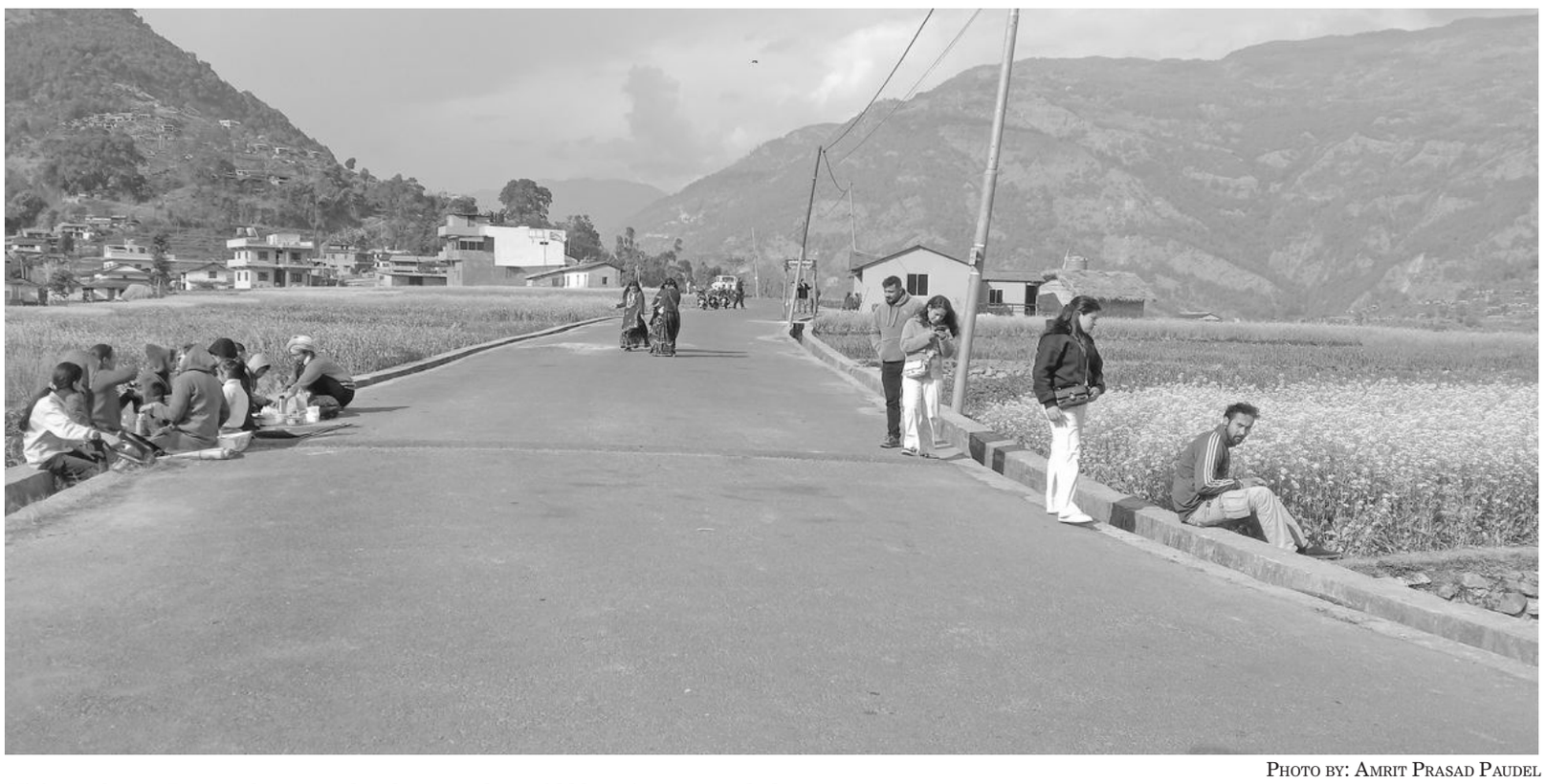


PHOTO BY: AMRIT PRASAD PAUDEL

Visitors throng Rantnechaur to take photographs amid blooming mustard plants

Tek Bahadur Thapa, the Ward Chair of Beni Municipality-1, said that Ratnechaur couldn't attract internal tourists due to a lack of promotion. However, many people came to know about the area's beauty because of social media, increasing internal tourists, he added.

Ratnechaur can be reached at a 15-minute ride from both Myagdi's headquarters Beni and Baglung's headquarters Baglung Bazzar.

Mannu Rawal, former president of Ratnechaur Jagaran Group, informed that more than 200 to 500 domestic tourists visit the mustard farm every day. He said that the crowd increases during holidays.

MAN KILLS PREGNANT WIFE IN NAWALPUR

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Nawalpur, Jan. 21

A man has killed his pregnant wife by attacking her with local weapons in Hupsekot Rural Municipality-6 of Nawalpur district of Gandaki province.

The deceased has been identified as Chanisara Magar, 34. Her husband Sher Bahadur Lamka Magar attacked her while she was sleeping with him and their daughters at home on Saturday night.

A mother of four daughters, Chanisara was hit by a spade and sickle-like large weapon. Chanisar was going to give birth to her baby in a week, said police.

Deputy Superintendent of Police (DSP) Bedh Bahadur Paudel said that the wife of Sher Bahadur was found murdered on her bed on Sunday morning after her daughters informed about the incident to the police.

Police arrested Sher Bahadur along with the weapons used in the murder from his home on Sunday morning.

According to police, Sher Bahadur who had gone to commit suicide by jumping into the river after the accident, returned home again.

During police interrogation, Sher Bahadur said that he killed his wife in a dream when somebody came to attack them.

"The incident happened when I tried to save my family when somebody came to attack us in my dream," said Sher Bahadur. Police have suspected that Sher Bahadur was suffering from mental illness.

ONE SCHOOL IN HUMLA REMAINS OPEN DURING WINTER

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Humla, Jan. 21

Sunkhani Primary School in Limi, Namkha Rural Municipality-6 in Humla has remained open although all other schools of the Humla district being closed for winter vacation.

Ward Chairman Paljor Tamang said that the school continued to operate classes in winter as per the collective decision of the ward office and the guardians. The decision was made to prevent the children's studies from being hampered.

Pindak Tamang, a teacher at Sunkhani, told *The Rising Nepal*, "Even though the community schools were required to close from December 31, this school is open and still teaching its students." Of the 151 community, religious, and institutional schools in the district, only Sunkhani is currently running classes.

The school has 19 students from child development to grade six. It has one teacher for the child development level provided by the government and has recruited three more through private sources.

The school remains open from 10 am to 4 pm every day.

Dhauligadh water supply project making notable progress

BY NETRA SHAHI
Jumla, Jan. 21

Jumla's largest water supply project, the Great Dhauligad Water Supply Project, is progressing fast. This project, supplying water to 8,695 households, is being executed in two packages.

According to Dipendra Bhatta, Acting Chief of the Federal Water and Sewerage Management Project in Jumla, the physical progress of the project is on track with the set targets.

The project has achieved physical progress of 43 per cent, with the financing progress reaching 34 per cent, Bhatta said. He further said that the ongoing work encompasses various aspects, including intake construction, DC, IC, pipeline construction, and tank construction, extending from the first intake to RVT.

In the designated area, tanks ranging from 100 to 600 cubic metres are currently under construction. Specifically, within Chandannath, Tatopani, and Gutichour Rural Municipalities, construction is under way for one 600-cubic-metre tank, one 300-cubic-metre tank, two 200-cubic-metre tank, and three tanks with capacities of 150 and 400 cubic metres, respectively. The construction efforts are in full swing in these locations, Bhatta informed.



PHOTO: NETRA SHAHI

Workers are busy laying pipes of the largest drinking water project in Jumla.

The construction of the transmission pipeline, covering a distance of 71.93 km under Package 1, is currently in progress. The development of the distribution pipeline, spanning 200 km from the tank to the stream in Package 2, too is proceeding at a rapid pace. About 130 to 140 km of the distribution pipeline has already been completed, according to the office.

Bhatta said that the construction companies Kankai JV Lalitpur and CMC Construction Pvt. Ltd. are actively involved in executing Package 1. An allocated budget of Rs. 544 million has been earmarked for the completion of Package 1, and for Package 2, the estimated amount is Rs. 370.7 million.

A contract for Package 1 was formally signed with the construction company on March 18, 2022, for a duration of 36 months. Similarly, the contract for Package 2 was signed on July 3, 2022, with a scheduled completion time frame of 30 months.

43,718 population to benefit

Amid a drinking water scarcity in Jumla headquarters, the Dhauligad water source, situated at an elevation of 3,918 metres above sea level, will bring relief to 43,718 individuals residing in Chandannath Municipality, Tatopani Rural Municipality, and Gutichour Rural Municipality of Jumla.

Civil Society President Raj Bahadur Mahat expressed confidence that this project has the potential to transform the region, particularly as the population increases and Jumla headquarters grapples with a drinking water shortage.

Highlighting the significance of the Dhauligad Drinking Water project as a National Pride Project, Mahat emphasized the need for collective efforts to take it forward.

Srijana Rawat, a resident of Chandannath Municipality-4, echoed the same sentiment, expressing optimism that the project would offer significant relief during the times when access to drinking water remains a pressing issue.

As per the office's report, the project has been progressing in alignment with the given targets. However, the action plan indicates a budgetary shortfall. For the ongoing year, the Great Dhauligad water supply project is operating with a regular budget of Rs. 120 million, but it appears that an additional Rs. 120 million will be required to meet the project's needs for the current fiscal year.

The request for the required funds has been submitted to the relevant agency. If the government ensures a budget of about Rs. 400 million for both the current and next fiscal years, the project aims to install 8,695 drinking water pipes as outlined in the plan within the specified timeframe.

Additionally, the Drinking Water Department has expressed intentions to explore opportunities for selling this water internationally, branding it as Yarsa mineral water.

School reconstruction in Bajhang making headway

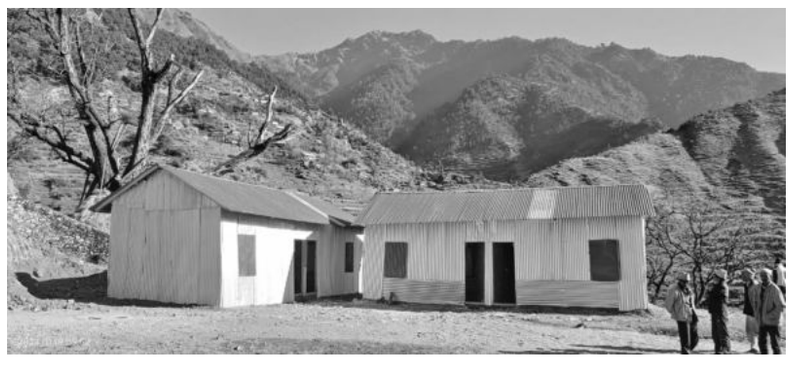


PHOTO: SAILENDRA ROKAYA

Temporary buildings of Gorkhali Basic School in Bajhang.

BY SHAILENDRA ROKAYA
Bajhang, Jan. 21

Reconstruction of the school buildings damaged by the earthquake of October 3, 2023, with Chainpur as its epicentre, is now in progress.

Reconstruction of 18 school buildings -- both completely and partially damaged in Khaptadchhanna Rural Municipality, has already started.

Uttam Bahadur Rokaya, Chairman of Khaptadchhanna Rural Municipality, said that after conducting a thorough inspection of the school buildings affected by the quake within the municipality, a comprehensive plan has been initiated. "This involves the construction of temporary shelters for completely damaged schools, retrofitting for the schools suffering minor damages, and overall reconstruction activities. These efforts are being executed under the 'Samriddha Khaptadchhanna Project' led by the non-governmental organisation, Read Nepal," said Roakaya.

He said, "Our village experienced significant damage in the earthquake. Private residences, and government buildings, particularly school buildings, suffered heavy damage. In the initial phase of reconstruction, Read Nepal is actively engaged in rebuilding the schools under the supervision and coordination of the rural municipality."

The earthquake had adversely affected children's studies, underscoring the urgency of school reconstruction. Out of the 38 schools in the municipality, the reconstruction process is being organised by categorising them based on the extent of damage—whether total, partial, or moderate, he added.

Satyaraj Pandey, the project engineer at Read Nepal, said that they have successfully erected 12 temporary shelters for five schools, which were completely damaged, forcing the students to take classes under the open sky. Additionally, retrofitting work is underway in 13 other schools, he added.

The education sector suffered significant damage in the earthquake, and the reconstruction of schools had been a challenge. Gorakhi Bahadur Khadka, the headmaster of Gorkhali Basic School, expressed relief that with the construction of temporary sheds, the necessity to conduct classes in the open sky has now come to an end.

He expressed concern over the fragile physical condition of his school and emphasised the need for drawing the attention of relevant authorities to long-term management. The widespread impact of the earthquake has left many buildings in the municipality with cracks and structural weaknesses.

Local educators are cautious while school children have to take classes in weak school buildings with constant fear of potential earthquakes. Recognising that a significant amount of funds would be required for permanent management of all the buildings in the rural municipality, the issue has been temporarily addressed due to budget constraints, he added.

Bahunidanda Health Post in Halesi shifts to new building

BY RAJ KUMAR BHATTARAI
Khotang, Jan. 21

Bahunidanda Health Post in Halesi Tuwachung Municipality-1 Bahunidanda in Khotang district has shifted from its previous cramped rented space to its newly constructed building. The 2-storey building was inaugurated by Bimala Rai, Mayor of Halesi Tuwachung Municipality.

Previously constrained by the limitations of a narrow-rented room, the health post now boasts improved facilities within its building.

The delay in completing the construction of the new building has forced the health centre to provide its services from a cramped rented space.

Earlier, the health post struggled to deliver services from a confined room of a deteriorating office building of the erstwhile Village Development Committee.

After the demolition of the structure for the construction of a new ward office building, the health centre was temporarily relocated, paying a monthly rent of 5,000 while its birthing centre had been operating in a rented house with a monthly rent of 4,000 since 2018.

The health post, thus, was operating from two different locations, paying a monthly rent of 9,000 in total.

The two rooms on the upper floor of the new building are designated as living quarters for health workers and one room for the kitchen while arrangements have been made for health services from six rooms on the ground floor.



PHOTO BY: RAJ KUMAR BHATTARAI

Newly built heath post of Bahundanda in Khotang.

Rai expressed optimism that the construction of the health post's new building would streamline service provision, making it more accessible for both staff and patients. Given the expansive geography of the ward, an urban health centre has been established in Bahunidanda to facilitate citizens.

Plans are underway to set up another health centre in Kaduwa, she said.

Gauri Parvati New Technical JV Lalitpur had taken responsibility for the construction of the health post.

The construction of the project experienced significant delays, leaving the building standing idle for an extended period.

The joint venture was entrusted with constructing five health post buildings in Bahunidanda, Mangaltar, Batase, Rakhabandel, and Dorpachiuridanda in Khotang.

The project is funded by the Saudi government through the National Reconstruction Authority for Rs. 70.4 million.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Write it on your heart that every day is the best day in the year.
-- Ralph Waldo Emerson

EDITORIAL

Quake-resilient Houses

Nepal has witnessed many small and big earthquakes with the deaths of thousands of people and loss of property worth billions in recent years. The 2015 Gorkha Earthquake dealt a big blow to the country, forcing the people to reel from shock and devastation for years. Some weeks back, the quake rattled a few districts in far west, including Jajarkot and Rukum West, giving another rude awakening to the country to vigorously carry out massive preparedness against the unpredictable disaster. The country is gradually gathering experiences in coping with the post-quake situation. When an earthquake razes an entire village to ground, this triggers multiple problems for the victims. The construction of some private houses is not enough. It demands the relocation of all villagers to safer sites because the quake-hit site may not be fit for the residences on geological ground.

The construction of integrated settlement is a viable solution to this problem. But a number of factors must be taken into account while building the integrated settlements. In addition to quake-resistant houses, the relocated areas must be appropriate for addressing the people's livelihood problems. They must be equipped with the basic services – water supply, electricity, internet, schools, hospital, local market and cultural aspects of the affected people. The quake-victims do not go to live in the newly built settlements, if they face hurdles towards their social, economic and cultural needs.

A news report, published in this daily the other day, reveals that the quake victims have not preferred to live in the integrated settlements constructed following the Gorkha earthquake owing to a number of reasons. The government built integrated settlement at Gumsipakha of Gorkha to relocate Laprak villagers but barely 25 families live there now. Only 50 of the 573 uniformly built houses are occupied. The houses are small, narrow, and built with little consideration for the climate of the locality or of the lifestyle of residents (especially of Gurung community). It has also no access to drinking water. The government's bid to relocate locals residing in Yasikai village of Rapti Municipality in Chitwan, to Kalitar area, which is six km west to the original place, came a cropper. The victims were provided land and Rs. 6.5 million each to construct new houses, but no one went there to live. These places lack prospect for farming, livestock and other kinds of practical employment.

Experts are of the view that settlements built in Gorkha, Chitwan and Dhading districts are likely to become ghost towns, with the local gradually deserting them. Building quake-resilient houses is expensive. However, they can be cost-effective if the local resources and technology are used. It is not necessary that house using concrete and big rods are only quake-resilient. Safe houses can be built with local materials such as finely cut and flat shaped stones, wood and bamboo. Earthquakes have destroyed the houses with round and oval stones that have rolling tendencies, and mud joints with no ties or interlocking system.

However, the structures made of flat stones have comparatively been less damaged, according to experts. There are several modalities of the construction of quake-resilient houses. They include Green, Resilient, and Inclusive Development Pathway (GRID), owner-driven modality, build back better approach, community partnership, and in-situ construction approach. Whatever the modality, it is imperative to follow national standards proposed by the Department of Urban Development to build the quake-resilient buildings.

Kathmandu's Allure Amidst Chaos

BISHALYA GAUTAM

One of the most serene capital cities in the world to visit is Kathmandu, often known as the city of temples, due to its vibrant architecture, multicultural population, and extensive history and culture. From the perspective of a tourist, it appears to be a metropolis with everything from temples to museums and if you drive for a little over an hour, you can also take in the breathtaking natural beauty of lush green forests and captivating mountains.

Moreover, its attraction is not only limited to tourists but also people all over the country willing to pursue their education and careers. Here lies a plethora of interests and opportunities to explore. The sole place in the nation where practically anything can be acquired with the right tools or contacts. It's reasonable to question if these attributes are real given their abundance.

This peaceful valley is the meeting place for people from all across the nation who come to share their virtues and to collectively conceal their vices. People swarm from one location to another, with some appreciating and others spitting at it. An ordinary person is limited to selecting one side. Either be an optimist and admire the only place in the country that is good enough to attract you or be pessimist and despise the only place in the country you could go.

This is where the opportunities and issues that come with living in a small nation's extremely dense capital are found. All races, religions, and creeds have been able to live in relative harmony as a result of it, but it has also brought in so many people that the streets are overflowing, the resources are running out, and the opportunities are disappearing.

The major problem of this revered valley is its inability to manage anything crucial. A perfect example of unplanned urbanisation where one is compelled to find beauty in this chaos. The never-ending wait for everything from the commute of daily lives to buying things. In our daily lives, the never-ending wait for necessities like grocery shopping and transportation can be a cause of aggravation and irritation. These seemingly simple but necessary chores for our survival can become major sources of stress when there are lengthy delays involved.

The nature of the present, which is extremely erratic, defines everything in this realm of duality, of hope and despair. Both the residents of this area and visitors who stop here on their way to other more fascinating locations overseas may never fully comprehend this place's mystique.

People in Kathmandu remain even after many have come and gone, administrations have fallen, and politics have changed. Not giving up, not expecting too much from reality. A paradise that is truly conflicted, where people may have changed or even died, but the collective will always remain the same and can never be clearly defined.

Complexity In Indo-Maldivian Ties



P Kharel

TIDE OF TIMES

Weeks after winning November election in the Maldives, during which Indian and some international news media projected him as "pro-China", President Mohamed Muizzu is embroiled in testing times, exasperated by a war of words in the social media between his supporters and pro-Indian sections.

The row erupted in the wake of Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi's much highlighted trip to the Indian islands of Lakshadweep, ostensibly to promote tourism. The Lakshadweep shares features similar to those the Maldives offers —and is located close to the Maldives.

Three Maldivian deputy ministers took the event as a bid to adversely affect tourism in their islands, to which tourism accounts for one-third of GDP. The trio made insulting remarks like "terrorist" and "clown" on the Indian premier. Although the three were subsequently suspended, the fire and fury will take time to die down. On the surface, the derogatory comments on Modi publicly triggered a row at personal level. Beneath the surface, the Modi government was closely watching the newly elected Muizzu team.

The undiplomatic comments from Male, therefore, added fuel to the fire of increasing distrust between the two governments. New Delhi might have assessed the patterns of development, starting from the election campaign during which Muizzu had made strong anti-India comments. The three ministers might have made the insulting remarks to echo their perceived sense of existing mood in their island nation.

Deepening divide

In a statement issued after the row broke out, the Maldives government issued a statement: "The government believes that the freedom of expression should be exercised in a democratic and responsible manner, and in ways that do not spread hatred, negativity, and hinder close relationships between the Maldives and international partners."

Muizzu's government move to regret the tirade expressed by its ministers did not have the desired effect on New Delhi. Many Indian celebrities and travel agencies quickly decided to boycott travel to the archipelago. Some of India's leading travel agencies declared that they would "stop promoting Maldives" following the anti-India comments its deputy minsters made.

Maldives wants to reduce heavy dependence on India. During the four-day visit to China last fortnight, Muizzu asked his counterpart Xi Jinping, the Chinese prime minister and other senior ministers for giving priority to his country's tourism industry. China, after all, accounts for 155 million of its citizens making holiday trips annually to foreign destinations.

The Maldives sought to reduce too much dependence on any one country. Prior to COVID-19, Chinese tourists for more than a decade accounted for the largest arrivals in the archipelago, whose tourism industry contributes to a third of the economy. Last year, India was ahead by a few thousand. Russian tourists generally account for No. 3 in this respect.

In 2022, China was the Maldives' second-biggest trading partner, accounting for almost 16 per cent of its total trading volume, surpassing India, which was the third largest with nearly 14 per cent. During his recent state visit, Moizzu made it a point to ask host President Xi, Premier of the State Council Li Qiang and other senior leaders to help boost his country's tourism industry.

Shortly after returning home from Beijing, the Moizzu government gave New Delhi a March 15 deadline for the 70 Indian military personnel to leave his country. The

> If the stalemate between the Maldives and India were left untended by restraint, it would leave room for an extended role to China.

personnel are stationed officially for assisting the island nation in maintaining a Dornier aircraft and two military helicopters provided by New Delhi. Responding to press inquiries about the deadline the Maldivian government had set for the Indian military personnel to return home, India's External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar said India "cannot guarantee" that time frame.

A joint press communiqué issued at the end of the Maldivian leader's China visit is to be viewed against the afore-mentioned background and events. It reiterated the "strategic significance" of Sino-Maldivian relations which would be upgraded to a "comprehensive strategic cooperative partnership". Of considerable meaning is that Beijing supports the Maldives "in upholding its national sovereignty, independence and national dignity" and "firmly opposes external interference in the internal affairs of the Maldives". China expressed its readiness to continue providing support for the archipelago nation "in areas that the Maldives deems as priorities".

On its part, the Maldives reaffirmed that Taiwan is part of China, and assured the hosts that their Belt and Road Initiative would receive "greater cooperation". Muizzu has already visited Turkey and China but is yet to announce any plan to visit New Delhi, which is a departure from the tradition of the island nation's newly elected executive head visiting the Indian capital first.

In an editorial, the official English news outlet of the Chinese Communist Party's Global Times wrote: "India should not underestimate China's opposition to unilateral military intervention." It warned that Beijing would "take action" if foreign troops were unilaterally sent troops to the Maldives.

Restraint needed

Beijing's support is rarely so explicit when addressing other countries. Overstretching things could complicate matters with India. Muizzu is armed with Beijing's assurances. If the stalemate between the Maldives and India were left untended by restraint, it would leave room for an extended role to China. Tough talk and threats marked Indian social media and news channel reports and debates. These do not help to smoothen things.

In view of the complex and complicated ties between South Asian nations, an effective activation of SAARC should add to the regular avenues of communication and dialogue among its leaders. If propelled with committed purpose and in the spirit of its declared objectives, SAARC can become a forum for regular communication at different levels culminating periodically at the highest levels.

On the eve of general elections three months away, Ram Mandir inaugural issues as well as the formation of I.N.D.I.A., a 28-party alliance with one-point programme of ending the 10-year rule by the Bharatiya Janata Party-led government, the recent events cannot be drawn as positive, or dismissive, events for the party that won the last two general elections with impressive showings. Until recently, major international media had concluded that Modi's party was likely to record a third consecutive victory this spring.

India's former Foreign Secretary Shyam Saran, in a newspaper article, advised patience to the Modi government. He said the obvious: "Strained Delhi-Maldives relations will boost Chinese presence in the Indian Ocean." And, for sure, it will if prudence gets sidelined.

(Professor Kharel specialises in political communication.)

Enhance National Assembly's Dignity



Ballav Dahal

The National Assembly (NA) is going to have 20 new faces soon. The election for 19 members is scheduled to be held on January 25 while the remaining one member will be nominated by the President on the recommendation of the federal government. The 19 seats will remain vacant from March 3. The constitution has a provision of an electoral college that elects 56 of the 59-member Upper House of the federal parliament. Three members are nominated by the President. The permanent House has two years' term for 19 of its members while another 20 have four years' tenure and the remaining ones enjoy the full term of six years. So, one-third of its members get elected every two years.

Electoral college

Provincial assembly members, mayors and deputy mayors of municipalities, sub-metropolises and metropolises, and chairpersons and vice-chairpersons of rural municipalities are in the electoral college. Out of 550 provincial assembly members, 549 will vote in the upcoming NA poll. One provincial assembly member from Madhes Province died in September last year. Similarly, a total of 1,498 heads and their deputies of the local bodies will be casting their vote. These elected people's representatives carry a collective weightage of 57,559. As per the existing law, a vote of the provincial assembly member has a credit of 53 while each of the chiefs and deputy chiefs of the local bodies has a value of 19.

A total of 52 candidates belonging to different political parties are now in the election fray. The ruling parties — Nepali Congress, CPN-Maoist Centre, CPN-Unified Socialist and Janata Samajbadi Party (JSP)—have fielded their common candidates for NA seats. According to a deal reached among the ruling parties, NC has 10 candidates while the CPN-Maoist Centre has six. The CPN-Unified Socialist and JSP have fielded two and one candidates, respectively. Considering the fact that the ruling parties hold a majority in all the provinces, they are likely to sweep NA poll this time. However, the CPN-UML, Rastriya Prajatantra Party, Janamat Party and Nepal Workers' and Peasants' Party are contesting the poll without forging any coalition.

The Election Commission (EC) has put election code of conduct in force for the NA poll since January 16. The code remains effective for all citizens, government bodies and officials till January 26. The election code stops anyone from using public resources for or against any poll candidate. It also prohibits distortion of election-related contents and information. Public institutions, including schools, and publications cannot be used as spaces for electioneering. Besides, the code does not allow anyone to produce, sell and distribute publicity of material bearing election symbols of any party/candidate or party logos. The poll code also puts a ban on the use of children for campaigning. No one is allowed to damage character of women, senior citizen, disabled people and community of sexual and gender minorities.

The code also bars candidates, other individuals and political parties from disseminating false, misleading and hateful information through social media as

> As the permanent House of the bicameral federal legislature, the NA has a crucial role to play when it comes to formulating effective laws and forcing the government to address vital national issues and people's problems.

well. It does not let anyone look down on candidates with an intention of impacting the poll. With the permission from the election body, ministers from federal and provincial governments and office bearers of the public offices can take part in canvassing. But they are not allowed to use government resources during election campaigns. As the permanent House of the bicameral federal legislature, the NA has a crucial role to play when it comes to formulating effective laws and forcing the government to address vital national issues and people's problems.

But this House has not only lost its dignity but has also failed to act as per the spirit of the constitution because of the political parties' tendency of choosing unbecoming candidates. However, in the initial phase, the Upper House had got comparatively better members. The constitution has envisaged NA as a club of experts contributing to various fields. But things have worsened because the political parties seem to have started picking their hard core cadres as candidates for NA members in place of specialists, intellectuals, experienced personalities and those having higher social repute. This sort of deviation has badly affected the NA's functioning.

Criticism

Looking at the list of NA members elected or nominated over the past few years, there is nothing to be satisfied with. Those who had lost elections to the House of Representatives have been serving as NA members. Incumbent Deputy Prime Minister and Home Minister Narayan Kaji Shrestha and Bamdev Gautam were brought to the Upper House after having lost elections to the Lower House. What is more mocking is that even a ward member candidate from Sindhupalchowk district is still working as NA member. Despite much criticism from public, the political parties appear to have repeated the same mistake. NC leader Krishna Prasad Sitaula, who lost parliamentary election from Jhapa-3 in November 2022, has now fielded his candidacy for a NA member. When such 'lucky' individuals are in abundance in the legislature, the nation is less likely to move ahead on the path of progress.

The party leaderships must have worked towards developing the NA into a chamber of experts and those having a lot of experience in different fields so as to enable it to function properly. But owing to a lack of sincerity and seriousness on the part of political leaderships, the NA has turned out to be a place to manage political cadres and those who are close to them.

(The author is a former deputy executive editor of this daily.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 22, 1974

Centenarian Kalwar Dies

Kalaiya, Jan 21: Centenarian Inarman Shaha Kalwar of Gunja Bhawanipur expires at the age of 120 years recently.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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Please email your contributions to:

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Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Make Roads Safe



The news story you ran, "*Construction materials piled-up on roadside cause accidents*", on Jan. 21 is a reminder of lawlessness that rules not only Nepalgunj Sub-metropolitan City, but the country as a whole. This mindless act of piling up construction materials in the public roads or spaces while construction private property show how indifferent the people as well as the administration are towards the road safety.

Our roads, where many thousands people perish every year, are already dangerous and this reckless behaviour is sure to invite more trouble. How can people using the road tolerate the daily annoyance it is causing? And why those who are causing this inconvenience can be so insensitive?

Most importantly, why are the concerned authorities turning a blind eye to this grave situation that is making the road a death trap? They must remove this obstruction without delay and set a precedent that such a dangerous act doesn't go without consequences.

Kapil Basyal
Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

An artist asked the gallery owner if there had been any interest in his paintings currently on display.

"I've got good news and bad news," the owner replied. "The good news is that a gentleman inquired about your work and wondered if it would appreciate in value after your death.

When I told him it would, he bought all 15 of your paintings."

"That's wonderful!" the artist exclaimed, "What's the bad news?"

Nationwide protests in Germany against mass deportation plans



PHOTO: AFP

People take part in a demonstration against racism and far-right politics, in Erfurt, eastern Germany, January 20, 2024.

AFP
German, Jan. 21

Around 250,000 people turned out across Germany on Saturday in protests against the far-right AfD, which sparked an outcry after it emerged that the party's members discussed mass deportation plans at a meeting of extremists.

Around 35,000 people joined a call under the banner "Defend democracy -- Frankfurt against the AfD", marching in Frankfurt, the financial heart of Germany, according to police.

A similar number, some carrying posters like "Nazis out", turned up in the northern city Hanover.

Another 30,000 turned out in the western city of Dortmund.

In all, demonstrations have been called in about 100 locations across Germany from Friday through the weekend, including in Berlin on Sunday.

ARD public television put the total turnout on Saturday at 250,000.

Not only politicians but also churches and Bundesliga coaches have urged people to stand up against the AfD.

The wave of mobilisation against the far-right party was sparked by a January 10 report by investigative outlet Correctiv, which revealed that AfD members had discussed the expulsion of immigrants and "non-assimilated citizens" at a meeting with extremists.

Among the participants at the talks was Martin Sellner, a leader of Austria's Identitarian Movement, which subscribes to the "great replacement" conspiracy theory that claims there is a plot by non-white migrants to replace Europe's "native" white population.

News of the gathering sent shockwaves across Germany at a time when the AfD is soaring in opinion polls, just months ahead of three major regional elections in eastern Germany where their support is strongest.

The anti-immigration party confirmed the presence of its members at the meeting, but has denied taking on the "remigration" project championed by Sellner.

But leading politicians including Chancellor Olaf Scholz, who joined a demonstration last weekend, said any plan to expel immigrants or citizens alike amounted to "an attack against our democracy, and in turn, on all of us".

He urged "all to take a stand -- for cohesion, for tolerance, for our democratic Germany".

Interior Minister Nancy Faeser went so far as to say in the newspapers of the Funke press group that the far-right meeting was reminiscent of "the horrible Wannsee conference", where the Nazis planned the extermination of European Jews in 1942.

Friedrich Merz, the leader of the opposition conservatives CDU party, also wrote on X that it was "very encouraging that thousands of people are demonstrating peacefully against right-wing extremism".

But besides members of the AfD, two members of the hard-right faction Werteunion of the CDU were also at the meeting near Potsdam cited by Correctiv.

Amid the outrage over the Potsdam meeting, the Werteunion's leader Hans-Georg Maassen said Saturday it had decided to split from the CDU.

Hamas says Gaza deaths top 25,000



PHOTO: AP

Lebanese soldiers and Civil defense workers gather next to a damaged car in the southern town of Bazouriyeh, Lebanon, Saturday, Jan. 20, 2024.

AFP
Gaza Strip, Jan. 21

Gaza's Hamas-run health ministry on Sunday said the death toll in the war-torn Palestinian territory breached 25,000 as Israel pushed its southward offensive and renewed bombardment in the north.

Israel is pressing its push against Hamas in southern Gaza as it seeks to destroy the Islamist militant group responsible for the deadliest attack in the country's history.

In early January, Israel's military said the Hamas command structure in northern Gaza had been dismantled, leaving only isolated fighters.

But witnesses told AFP Israeli boats were bombarding Gaza City and other areas in the north early Sunday. Hamas has also reported heavy combat in the north.

"Dozens are still under the rubble," the Hamas government's media office said, adding that the dead and injured "could not be transferred to hospitals due to the continued artillery shelling on... Khan Yunis and the Tal al-Hawa area in Gaza City and the north".

The Israeli army said it "eliminated a number of terrorists" in the main southern city of Khan Yunis and killed 15 militants in northern Gaza over the past day.

Thick plumes of smoke billowed above Khan Yunis on Sunday morning, AFP journalists saw.

The October 7 attacks by Hamas resulted in the deaths of about 1,140 people, mostly civilians, according to an AFP tally based on official Israeli figures.

Israel's relentless bombardment and ground offensive have killed at least 25,105 people in Gaza, mostly women and children, according to the Hamas-run health ministry.

Militants also seized about 250 hostages during the October attacks.

Israel says around 132 remain in Gaza, of whom at least 27 captives are believed to have been killed, according to an AFP tally based on Israeli figures.

Iran-backed militants strike US-led base in Iraq



AFP
Washington, Jan. 21

Iran-backed militants launched ballistic missiles at a base hosting US forces in western Iraq, causing one Iraqi and possible American casualties, the US Central Command said Saturday.

"Multiple ballistic missiles and rockets were launched by Iranian-backed militants in western Iraq targeting al-Assad Airbase," CENTCOM said in a social media post, which placed the time of the attack at 6:30 pm Baghdad time (1530GMT) Saturday evening.

Most of the projectiles were intercepted by the base's air defense systems but "others impacted on the base," the statement said.

"A number of US personnel are undergoing evaluation for traumatic brain injuries. At least one Iraqi service member was wounded," it added.

Since mid-October, there have been dozens of attacks on US and coalition forces in Iraq and Syria, deployed there to fight jihadists of the Islamic State group.

Most have been claimed by "Islamic Resistance in Iraq," a loose alliance of Iran-linked armed groups that oppose US support for Israel in the Gaza conflict.

The group said in a press release Saturday that it had carried out the latest attack.

The use of ballistic missiles marks an escalation in the attacks on US forces in Iraq and Syria, who had previously been targeted with lower-tech rockets and drones.

Saturday's air base attack comes amid soaring tensions in the Middle East following the outbreak of the Israel-Hamas war on October 7.

Five members of Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps were also killed in a strike Saturday in Damascus that Tehran blamed on Israel, threatening reprisals.

NKorea stresses alignment with Russia against US

AP
South Korea, Jan. 21

North Korea said Sunday that Russian President Vladimir Putin expressed his willingness to visit the North at an unspecified "early date" as the countries continue to align in the face of their separate, intensifying confrontations with the United States.

The North Korean Foreign Ministry highlighted Putin's intent for a visit following North Korean Foreign Minister Choe Son Hui's meetings with Putin and Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov in Moscow last week. The ministry said in a statement published by state media that the two countries agreed to further strategic and tactical cooperation with Russia to establish a "new multi-polarized international order," a reference to their efforts to build a united front against Washington.

Putin had already confirmed his willingness to visit the capital, Pyongyang, at a convenient time during his meeting with North Korean leader Kim Jong Un in Russia's Far East in September. One of the few world leaders openly supporting Putin's war on Ukraine, Kim has been actively boosting the visibility of his ties with Russia in an attempt to break out of diplomatic isolation and strengthen his footing, as he navigates a deepening nuclear standoff with Washington, Seoul and Tokyo. In a separate statement on Sunday, the North's Foreign Ministry condemned the U.N. Security Council for calling an emergency meeting over the country's latest ballistic test, which state media described as a new intermediate-range solid-fuel missile tipped with a hypersonic warhead. The ministry said the test-firing on Jan. 14 was among the country's regular activities to improve its defense capabilities and that it didn't pose a threat to its neighbors.



PHOTO: AP

North Korean Foreign Minister Choe Son Hui arrives to meet with Russian President Vladimir Putin at the Kremlin in Moscow, Russia, Tuesday, Jan. 16, 2024.

South Korea on Thursday urged the Security Council "to break the silence" over North Korea's escalating missile tests and threats. Russia and China, both permanent members of the council, have blocked U.S.-led efforts to increase sanctions on North Korea over its recent weapons tests, underscoring a divide deepened over Russia's war on Ukraine.

The alignment between Pyongyang and Moscow has raised international concerns about alleged arms cooperation, in which the North provides Russia with munitions to help prolong its fighting in Ukraine, possibly in exchange for badly needed economic aid and military assistance to help upgrade Kim's forces. Both Pyongyang and Russia have denied accusations by Washington and Seoul about North Korean arms transfers to Russia.

North Korea's Foreign Ministry, in comments published by state media, said Choe and the Russian officials in their meetings expressed a "strong will to further strengthen strategic and tactical cooperation in defending the core interests of the two countries and establishing a new multi-polarized international order."

Russia expressed "deep thanks" to North Korea for its "full support" over its war on Ukraine, the North Korean ministry said. It said Choe and the Russian officials expressed "serious concern" over the United States' expanding military cooperation with its Asian allies that they blamed for worsening tensions in the region and threatening North Korea's sovereignty and security interests.

PRISM

Deer rescued from frozen pond

Michigan: Firefighters in Michigan came to the rescue of a deer found stranded in the frigid waters of a frozen pond.

The city of Wyoming said in a Facebook post that firefighters responded when a deer fell through the ice covering a pond off 52nd Street.

A photo shared by the city shows a firefighter breaking through the ice to make a path for the deer to be towed back to shore.

The city said the incident should serve as "a reminder to always watch animals and children around water as ice may be thin."

Female lesser kudu born

Ohio: Officials at the Cincinnati Zoo & Botanical Garden in Ohio announced the birth of a female lesser kudu calf currently being cared for by zoo staff.

The zoo said in a news release that the kudu was born Monday and zookeepers decided to step in and care for the newborn after first-time mother Sabi appeared uninterested in the baby.

"We didn't see nursing or much interest from first-time mom Sabi, so we stepped in and fed the calf," Eric Byrd, zoological manager at the Cincinnati Zoo, said in the news release. "We were also able to give the baby plasma that had been collected from her mom and saved when she had a hoof procedure. This will provide passive transfer of antibodies."

Officials said the baby is being kept close to her mother in the hopes that the pair will bond.

(Agencies)

Air pollution, politics pose cross-border challenges in South Asia

AP
Pakistan, Jan. 21

The air smells burnt in Lahore, a city in Pakistan's east that used to be famous for its gardens but has become infamous for its terrible air quality.

Toxic smog has sickened tens of thousands of people in recent months. Flights have been cancelled. Artificial rain was deployed last December to battle smog, a national first. Nothing seems to be working.

Lahore is in an air shed, an area where pollutants from industry, transportation and other human activities get trapped because of local weather and topography so they cannot disperse easily. Air sheds also contribute to cross-border pollution. Under certain wind conditions, 30% of pollution in the Indian Capital New Delhi can come from Pakistan's Punjab province, where Lahore is the capital. There are six major air sheds in South Asia, home to many of the world's worst polluted cities.

Experts are calling for greater cross-border cooperation among countries such as Pakistan, Bangladesh and India to address air pollution together rather than working in silos on a city-by-city basis. But it's a tall order when political relations in the region are fraught.

Ties between India and Pakistan are broken. Their interactions are riddled with animosity and suspicion. They have fought three wars, built up their armies and developed nuclear weapons. Travel restrictions and hostile bureaucracies largely keep people from crossing the border for leisure, study and work, although the countries make exceptions for religious pilgrimages.

"There's a recognition among the technical and scientific community that air pollution doesn't need a visa to travel across borders," said Pakistani analyst Abdi Solera, from the non-profit Sustainable Development Policy Institute. The culprits and problems are the same on both sides of the India-Pakistan border, he said, so it makes no sense for one province to implement measures if a neighbouring province across the border isn't adopting the same practices.



PHOTO: AP

A sweeper cleans an area as smog envelops the area and reduces visibility in Lahore, Pakistan, Thursday, Jan. 11, 2024.

Regional and international forums offer opportunities for candid discussions about air pollution, even if governments aren't working together directly or publicly, Suleri said, adding that countries should treat air pollution as a year-round problem, rather than a seasonal one arriving with cold weather.

"Airshed management needs a regional plan," he said. "But 2024 is an election year in India and Pakistan, and government-to-government cooperation hasn't reached that level."

Pakistan is weeks away from voting in national parliamentary elections. So far, only the former foreign minister and political party leader Bilawal Bhutto Zardari has pledged heavy investment in climate adaptability, following record-breaking floods that killed more than 1,700 people.

In India, air pollution doesn't figure as a core issue that people would vote on, said Bhargav Krishna, a fellow at the New Delhi-based Sustainable Futures Collaborative think-tank. But the experience or impact of climate change could make people think about how they vote.

Krishna said that regional elections sometimes see air pollution-related promises. "It was a feature of every party's election manifesto in the New Delhi elections in 2020," he noted.

TODAY IN HISTORY

1555 – The Ava Kingdom falls to the Taungoo Dynasty in what is now Myanmar.
1890 – The United Mine Workers of America is founded in Columbus, Ohio.
1941 – World War II: British and Commonwealth troops capture Tobruk from Italian forces during Operation Compass.
1947 – KTLA, the first commercial television station west of the Mississippi River, begins operation in Hollywood.
1957 – Israel withdraws from the Sinai Peninsula.
1957 – The New York City "Mad Bomber", George P. Metesky, is arrested in Waterbury, Connecticut and charged with planting more than 30 bombs.
2007 – At least 88 people are killed when two car bombs explode in the Bab Al-Sharqi market in central Baghdad, Iraq.

PM INSTRUCTS BPKIHS VC TO CONVENE MEETING PROMPTLY



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 21

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has directed the Vice Chancellor of BP Koirala Institute of Health Sciences, Dr. Prahlad Karki, to promptly convene an executive committee meeting.

In a meeting held at Singha Darbar on Sunday, Prime Minister Prachanda advised Dr. Karki to conduct the meeting in Dharan, finalising the interview date and proposing amendments to the regulations for Senate consideration.

Emphasising the importance of adhering to the law, PM Prachanda also called Vice-Chancellor and Health Minister Mohan Bahadur Basnet, instructing them to schedule the Senate meeting within 21 days from today.

Earlier, on January 2, the Prime Minister urged Minister Basnet to address the concerns of the teachers, employees, and doctors.



PHOTO: SAGAR BASNET/TRN

President Ramchandra Paudel presenting commendation letters to participants of 46th Buddhist Observation Tour in the capital on Sunday.

FOREIGN INTERFERENCE IN POLITICS INCREASING: LINGDEN

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Damak, Jan. 21

Rastriya Prajatantra Party chairman and former Deputy Prime Minister Rajendra Lingden said that foreign interference in Nepali politics has increased due to the self-interest of political leaders and an imbalanced foreign policy.

He also pointed out the risk of Nepal becoming a battleground for powerful nations. Speaking at the Birtamod New Awareness Campaign programme on Sunday, Lingden said that Nepali politics was affected by the mindset of the political leaders who believed they needed foreign support to win the election and become prime minister after winning it.

Stating Nepal had an agreement allowing foreign embassies in Nepal to invest directly up to Rs. 200 million in any projects, he said such an agreement was an unfortunate situation for the country.

Furthermore, he said that a situation might arise a situation in which the local authorities would seek assistance from embassies instead of the Nepal Government for development and project funds.

He said that every Nepali citizen was in debt of Rs. 81,000 and the number was increasing every day.

Bhainse-Bhimphedi road upgrading in full swing

BY RAMMANI DAHAL
Makwanpur, Jan. 21

The upgrading work of the Bhainse-Bhimphedi road section which connects Hetauda with Kathmandu is now moving in full swing.

Earlier, the upgrading work on the Bhaise-Bhimphedi road section was moving at a slow pace due to conflict over compensation for the land required for its expansion at various places.

After the problem of compensation was resolved, the upgrading process has taken a momentum.

The Bagmati Province government has started the road upgrading work. Concerns were also raised about the slow pace of the upgrading work in the Province Assembly meeting.

Since the beginning of the previous term of the Provincial Assembly, the members of the Province Assembly had been raising their voices about the need to upgrade the short-distance road connecting Hetauda-Kathmandu which was in a dilapidated state.

The locals of Bhimphedi Rural Municipality Ward No. 4 had demanded compensation for their house and land during the expansion of the road, which caused obstacles to the upgrading process. The blacktopping of the road, including widening, has moved on smoothly after the three-year dispute related to compensation for houses was resolved in Golping and other areas of ward no. 4.

Around 25 houses have been removed in the area after resolving the dispute over compensation for houses.

According to the Directorate of Transport Infrastructure, Hetauda under the Ministry of Physical Infrastructure Development of Bagmati Province, blacktopping works will be completed in areas where there is no dispute over the compensation.

Spokesperson of the Directorate, engineer Hari Prasad Ojha, said that there were obstructions in various places under the Bhaise-Bhimphedi, but now the problems were resolved in more than 90 per cent of places and blacktopping work had begun.

Stating that the problem of compensation has been resolved in about 300 meters areas of the Golping area of ward no. 4, he said that the dispute in the Chiuri Bagichha area remained the same.

The problem in Chiuri Bagaichha has not been resolved in about three meters area as the locals are not satisfied with the evaluation of their houses, he said.

Initiatives are being taken to solve the problem, he added.

The work of upgrading the 11-kilometre five-meter road from Bhaise to Bhimphedi is going on in full swing, except in the areas where there is a dispute over compensation and the landslide-prone areas.

Work has been moving in way that the blacktopping work would be over by February/March, except in some parts of Dhorsing and near Bhaise, where there is a problem of landslide.

Under the upgrading of the road, road widening, blacktopping, construction of wall, and drain construction will be carried out.

Informing that 80 per cent of the work has been completed, spokesperson Ojha said that after the blacktopping, the beautification and finishing work of the road will be done.

The construction company had signed an agreement to upgrade the Bhainse-Bhimphedi road section within two years on August 8, 2020, but the construction work was delayed due to COVID-19, and dispute over compensation for the house.

The construction cost has also increased with the extension of the time. Initially, the contract was signed with the construction company to upgrade the road at a cost of around Rs. 390 million, but now the construction cost has been increased to Rs. 426.5 million.

According to Ojha, the deadline for the construction of the road has been extended twice as the construction work was not completed on time as per the initial agreement.

The deadline was extended by one year and nine months in two phases.

Five generations of a family living together in harmony

BY PREM RAJ SIMKHADA
Kalikot, Jan. 21

In Kalikot, a district where it is uncommon for more than two generations to coexist due to familial disagreements, a Bohora family from Barekot Rural Municipality Ward No. 1 in the erstwhile Ramidadan Village Development Committee Ward No. 2 defies the norm by living together harmoniously for five generations.

Dhanjit Bohora, 81, and Maan Bahadur Bohora, 76, are two brothers from Sinakot. They have one son each, working as government employees, and six grandsons and a granddaughter, all pursuing education in various cities across the country.

Reflecting on their remarkable family continuity, Maan Bahadur Bohora, who retired from teaching, shared that the family's unity persists even after the demise of the youngest brother at the age of 23. Following the tragedy, the two Bohora brothers remained together, reinforcing the family's bond.

During an interview with The Rising Nepal, a member of the family expressed their commitment to maintaining their heritage. Maan Bahadur emphasised that the elders advised their grandchildren not to break familial ties. The Bohora family takes pride in their enduring togetherness across five generations, a testament to their commitment to preserving their legacy.

Maan Bahadur elaborated on their history, reminiscing about a time when education was less common, and his elder brother, Dhanjit Bohora, would carry essential supplies like rice, pulses, and salt from the village while studying in Khalanga, the headquarters of Jajarkot district. Despite facing challenges, the family remains united. Maan Bahadur spoke about his close bond with his brother's family and the shared responsibilities within the household. Even after the passing away of family members, including wives and in-laws, they continued to support each other.

Dhanjit Bohora, the eldest brother, emphasised the importance of mutual understanding and support within the family. He cited his role as a cowherd, contributing his earnings to support his brother's teaching career and the subsequent education of both his sons. This support has allowed the next generation to pursue higher education, including MBBS, BBS, BAC, BBA, and IAS, with the financial burden borne collectively by the two brothers.

In their contented coexistence, the family serves as an inspiring example of familial unity. Dhanjit Bohora concluded that the key to their enduring togetherness is a mindset of shared responsibility and understanding. Their story serves as a valuable lesson in an era where such family ties are increasingly rare.



FILE PHOTO: PREM RAJ SIMKHADA/TRN

Bohora family celebrating Dashain festival.

NAM remains...

said PM Prachanda and added that he had emphasized that the NAM, as the largest representative organization after the United Nations, should play an important role in paving the way to stability and prosperity.

PM Prachanda said that the Himalayas are home to 15 per cent of the world's population and 50 per cent of earth's biodiversity. He said, "Mountains are very important for the living creatures of the world. Nepal, a mountainous country, is in the grip of climate change."

He also reiterated the issue that Nepal has been advocating for the protection of the Himalayas and mountain ecosystems and the human communities living there, and also called on the international community to support the voice of the Himalayas.

While in Kampala, PM Prachanda interacted with the Nepali community there and discussed the existing opportunities and challenges for Nepalis in Uganda and the African continent.

In the sidelines of the summit, he met President of Sri Lanka, Ranil Wickremesinghe, and held a bilateral delegation-level discussion on the occasion.

At the meeting, he emphasized on the need to make the South Asian Regional Cooperation Organisation (SAARC) active and dynamic, and noted that the two countries should play a common role for that. The two delegations also talked about conducting direct flight from Sri Lanka to Gautam Buddha International Airport in Lumbini.

10,159 temporary shelters...

In Nalgadh Municipality, the government has sent Rs. 202 million to the local disaster fund and of them, the local government had disbursed Rs. 116 million in the accounts of the quake victims for constructing temporary housings. There are 8,097 total beneficiaries in the municipality and of them, 7,150 beneficiaries have received their installments.

Administrative Officer Sharma said that the municipality informed the local administration that 27,091 of the 42,524 earthquake-affected people have taken the money for temporary housing.

According to the information released by the District Administration Office, 32,365 families are living under the tarpaulins. Even two and half months after the earthquake, all the victims have not yet been able to get the first tranche for constructing temporary housing.

Police adjustment process...

DPM Shrestha said that he gave the instructions to the Chief of Nepal Police and Armed Police of Madhes Province, the Chief District Officer of all the eight districts, and the Superintendent of Police on Sunday morning.

He had a separate discussion with the provincial security officials in the morning at Lalbandi.

DPM Shrestha said that businesses such as bringing in small quantities of goods but going across the border more than 50 times a day, and giving money to the police every time they cross the border, were not acceptable anymore.

After the inauguration of the prison building, DPM Shrestha laid the foundation stone of a bridge to be built over the Lakhandehi River in Lalbandi Municipality-12, Jiyajor, on Sunday.

Taudaha sees a tumble in...

The Bird Counting Campaign spans 15 river systems, including Koshi, Bagmati, Manohara, Karra, Rapti, Narayani, Khageri, Dhungre, Telar, Dano, Tinau, Bijaypur, Rara, Paschim Rapti, Karnali, and Mahakali.

According to Dr. Baral, in case of Kathmandu Valley, the escalating trend of urban expansion has led to habitat loss and disruption, adversely impacting the ecosystems that serve as crucial havens for migratory birds. Uncontrolled development, coupled with insufficient conservation measures, has further exacerbated the challenges faced by these avian species.

The encroachment upon rivers and wetlands, critical habitats for various bird species, has disrupted the natural balance and accessibility of resources, contributing significantly to the observed decline in the local bird population during the winter months, he said.

Addressing these issues necessitates a comprehensive approach, integrating urban planning, environmental conservation, and sustainable development practices to ensure the preservation and restoration of avian habitats in the Kathmandu Valley, Baral added.

Consecration of Ayodhya Ram Temple to be celebrated in Janakpur

BY OUR CORRESPONDENTS
Dhalkebar / Jaleshwor, Jan. 21

A total of 125,000 traditional oil lamps are going to be lit at Janaki Temple in Janakpurdham on Monday on the occasion of the consecration of the Ram Temple in Ayodhya of India scheduled for January 22.

Ramatapeshwor Das, the Chief Priest of Janaki Temple, said that the consecration day was significant for both Nepal and India and urged people to celebrate the occasion. Stating that they have made special arrangements to celebrate the day, he said that they had already sent various jewellery items made of silver and gold including a silver bow and arrow to the Ram Temple in Ayodhya.

Chief Priest Das and temple's successor Ramroshan Das, invited from the Ram Temple, had already arrived in Ayodhya on Thursday. Successor Das had even urged Madhes Province Chief Minister Saroj Kumar Yadav to announce a public holiday on the occasion, but, no decision has been taken on this regard as of Sunday afternoon, informed the office of the Chief Minister.

Meanwhile, many temples in Madhes Province are bedecked with decorations with a Hindu theme and flags bearing the name of Ram (Hindu God).

Several local levels in Madhes Province have given a public holiday on Monday to celebrate the occasion.

Shiva Chandra Chaudhary, general secretary of Jaleshwor Chamber of Commerce and Industry, said that there was no doubt on saying that people in Mithilanchal start their day with a chant 'Jai Shree Ram' (Victory of Lord Ram). He said, "The chants of 'Jai Shree Ram' reverberate not just in Jaleshwor but in the entire Mahotari district and Mithilanchal. We all are excited for the consecration of the Ram Temple."

He said, "Mother Sita is the daughter of Mihtilanchal. While the chant 'Jai Shree Ram' is echoing in India, the chant 'Jai Siyaram' is resounding in Janakpur and Mithilanchal of Nepal. "

Every house and shops in Jaleshwor, also a headquarters of Mahottari, are decorated with lights, flowers and flags bearing Lord Ram.

Issuing a press statement, Jaleshwor Municipality Mayor Suresh Shah Sonar urged its denizens to celebrate the consecration of the Ram Temple in joy. He also said that the consecration of the Ram Temple was a matter of pride to Nepali since Mother Sita was from Mithilanchal.

TIA CUSTOMS SEIZES HALF KG OF GOLD



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 21

The Tribhuvan International Airport Customs Office seized half a kilo of gold from the airport on Sunday.

A passenger who landed at the Tribhuvan Airport from Doha, Qatar, was arrested with half a kilo of gold brought in a semi-liquid form.

Dr. Tok Raj Pandey, chief of the TIA Customs Office, said that acting upon a tip-off, the customs office detained Khagendra Darji, of Jhapa, along with the 499 grams of gold. Darji, who came to Kathmandu from Doha, Qatar, by flight H9 564 of Himalaya Airlines, was arrested with the gold brought in liquid form hiding it inside his waist.

Dr. Pandey said that further investigation is being conducted regarding whether the recovered gold was brought by Darji himself or if he was just a porter.

Three winners selected in Millennium Kids International



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 21

Three winners have been selected in the 'Millennium Kids International 2024,'a beauty pageant show designed to showcase the talents of children.

Three winners, including junior girls, boys, and senior girls, were selected amid a competition held on Saturday in Kathmandu. Ivan Shrestha emerged as the winner in the junior boys' category, while Ilona Karki secured the top title in the junior category.

Likewise, Smarika Bhattarai was declared the winner for senior girls.

Along with their titles, all the top winners received various gifts and opportunities as prizes.

Additionally, four runners-up were selected in the competition.

Aarav Adhikari, Utsarga Dhakal, Shreejal Yadav, and Samprabha Jung KC became the first, second, third, and fourth runners-up, respectively, in the junior boys' category.

Likewise, Nibitsa Jha, Sikum Subba, Alankrita Bhattarai and Ojaswi Silwal became the first, second, third, and fourth runners-up, respectively, for junior girls.

In the senior girls' category, Angel Gahatraj was chosen as the first runner-up, Sanvi Bista as the second runner-up, and Krishu Bhandari as the third runner-up.

The competition, organised with stage performances by children in an attractive style, aimed to empower children to build the future, as informed by Raj Faizu, the Managing Director of Radiant Event Management Agency, an international model, and fashion coach.

Creator Of Deepfake Video Of Actor Rashmika Mandanna Arrested

AGENCIES
New Delhi, Jan. 21



Delhi Police on Saturday said it has arrested a B-Tech graduate from Andhra Pradesh in connection with a deepfake video of actor Rashmika Mandanna that was widely circulated on social media.

The accused identified as 23-year-old Eemani Naveen, a native of Guntur, Andhra Pradesh, had created the video to increase the followers on his fan page of Rashmika Mandanna on Instagram, an official said.

On November 10, an FIR was registered under sections 465 (punishment for forgery) and 469 (forgery for purpose of harming reputation) of the Indian Penal Code (IPC) and sections 66C and 66E of the Information Technology Act at the Intelligence Fusion and Strategic Operations (IFSO) Unit of the Delhi Police's Special Cell.

The case was registered on the complaint of the Delhi Commission for Women (DCW).

Soon after registering the FIR, the IFSO Unit wrote to Meta to get the URL and other details to identify the accused who made the video and put it on the social media, the official added.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP), IFSO, Dr Hemant Tiwari, said that Naveen created the deepfake video of the actress just to increase the followers and posted it on the fan page on October 13.

He had used the AI (artificial intelligence) technique with the help of Youtube to make the video, he added.

The DCP said that the fan following of this page increased from 90,000 to 1,08000 within two weeks due to the deepfake video.

When Naveen later realised that it became a national sensation and also saw tweets from famous film stars against the said Deepfake video, he got scared and deleted the said posts from the Instagram Channel and also changed the name of Insta channel, he added.

Tiwari further said that Naveen had also deleted the relevant digital data from his devices.

Another officer said it was found during the preliminary analysis that the original video was uploaded by a British Indian girl on her Instagram account on October 9, 2023, and later on deepfake video of Mandanna was created and circulated on various social media platforms.

The officer said that more than 500 social media accounts related to the alleged deepfake videos were analysed during the investigation.

After the deep analysis and interrogation of suspected persons, finally Naveen's account was traced on Instagram, the officer said.

A team of Inspector Hansraj Swami

'Jigree' to release on February 16

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 21



Three distinct posters of the film 'Jigree' have been released along with its release date.

The film is set to hit screens on February 16, accompanied by the tagline 'Yeuta Aalu Jasto, Arko Tama Jasto,' which translates into English as 'One is like a potato, the other is like a bamboo shoot.' Directed by Akash Magar, 'Jigree' blends elements of comedy, crime, action and drama.

The cast features Abhay Raj Baral, Akash Magar, Sushil Raj Pandey, Pashupati Rai, Supriya Rana, Roshan Subedi, Jeevan Baral, Basudev Khanal, Nabin Lamsal, Kedar Shrestha, Diwakar Ghimire, Sushila Laxmi Maharjan and others. The film narrates the story of two boys with contrasting behaviours who arrive in Kathmandu with numerous aspirations.

The central theme revolves around the struggles of these young individuals to survive in Kathmandu amidst soaring prices and shortages.

The film endeavours to depict the challenges faced by ordinary Nepali youth, showcasing their hardships and the ensuing events through a blend of comedy, crime, and action.

Kusum Thapa Magar serves as the executive producer, with Kumar Shrestha as the producer of the film.

The cinematography of the film is directed by Sumit Bhatt and Somit Majhi while Sarun Manandhar edited the film.

Reformed mobster went after 'one last score' when he stole Judy Garland's ruby slippers from 'Oz'

AP
Los Angeles, Jan. 21



The aging reformed mobster who has admitted stealing a pair of ruby slippers that Judy Garland wore in "The Wizard of Oz" gave into the temptation of "one last score" after an old mob associate led him to believe the famous shoes must be adorned with real jewels to justify their $1 million insured value.

Terry Jon Martin's defense attorney finally revealed the 76-year-old's motive for the 2005 theft from the Judy Garland Museum in the late actor's hometown of Grand Rapids, Minnesota, in a new memo filed ahead of his Jan. 29 sentencing in Duluth, Minnesota.

The FBI recovered the shoes in 2018 when someone else tried to claim an insurance reward on them, but Martin wasn't charged with stealing them until last year.

Martin pleaded guilty in October to using a hammer to smash the glass of the museum door and display case to take the slippers. He had hoped to harvest real rubies from the shoes and sell them. But a fence, a person who deals in stolen goods, informed him the rubies were glass and Martin got rid of the slippers less than two days after he took them, he said.

Defense attorney Dane DeKrey said in his memo that an unidentified former mob associate tempted Martin to steal the shoes, even though he hadn't committed a crime in nearly 10 years after his last prison stint.

"At first, Terry declined the invitation to participate in the heist. But old habits die hard, and the thought of a 'final score' kept him up at night," DeKrey wrote. "After much contemplation, Terry had a criminal relapse and decided to participate in the theft."

DeKrey and prosecutors are recommending the judge sentence Martin to time served because he is physically incapable of presenting a threat to society. Martin is in hospice care with a life expectancy of less than six months. He needs oxygen at all times because of his chronic obstructive pulmonary disorder and was in a wheelchair at his most recent court appearance. Even if he were sentenced to prison, his poor health might be grounds for a compassionate release.

Martin had no idea about the cultural significance of the ruby slippers and had never seen the movie. Instead, DeKrey said he was just looking for one last big score, and the "old Terry" with a lifelong history of crimes like burglary and receiving stolen property beat out the "new Terry" who seemed to "finally put his demons to rest" after being released from prison in 1996 and became "a contributing member of society."

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: You might not be willing to express everything that you're holding inside. Normally you may wear your heart on your sleeve in life and prefer to burst forward into situations.

Taurus: Partnerships can feel unstable at this time. You may be working with a peer or emotionally connected to someone who seems unsteady or more volatile at this time, and because of their emotions.

Gemini: An emotional tug-of-war with someone you care about may take over your day. You may be falling on opposite sides of an issue, and while trying to create an all-out verbal battle to get your way.

Cancer: You have the emotional tools to take on whatever comes your way. You're no stranger to being overwhelmed with feelings that you have to carry alone at times, as you're ruled by the poignant Moon, so you might be more used.

Leo: You might feel suppressed by others. It's possible that you're used to being able to express yourself freely with your friends and family, but at this moment, you may be in a group that frowns on it.

Virgo: Needing to please authority figures could lead to you swallowing your words. A VIP may show up at your place of work or stop you on the street, and while you may not feel like listening and working with their demands.

Libra: Quiet dreams and subtle goals are still crucial to your soul. While you may want to tell people about a recent project that you are working toward, telling others right now could invite criticism or influence that would be negative for you.

Scorpio: A previous agreement may begin to feel restrictive. Whether this is a bill you agreed to pay, a job you said you'd handle, or just a coffee date that you don't have the energy to attend, you might be wanting to back.

Sagittarius: Someone may be encouraging you to do something that you don't want to do. Even if their intentions are pure, they could be valuing their desires over what works best for your personality.

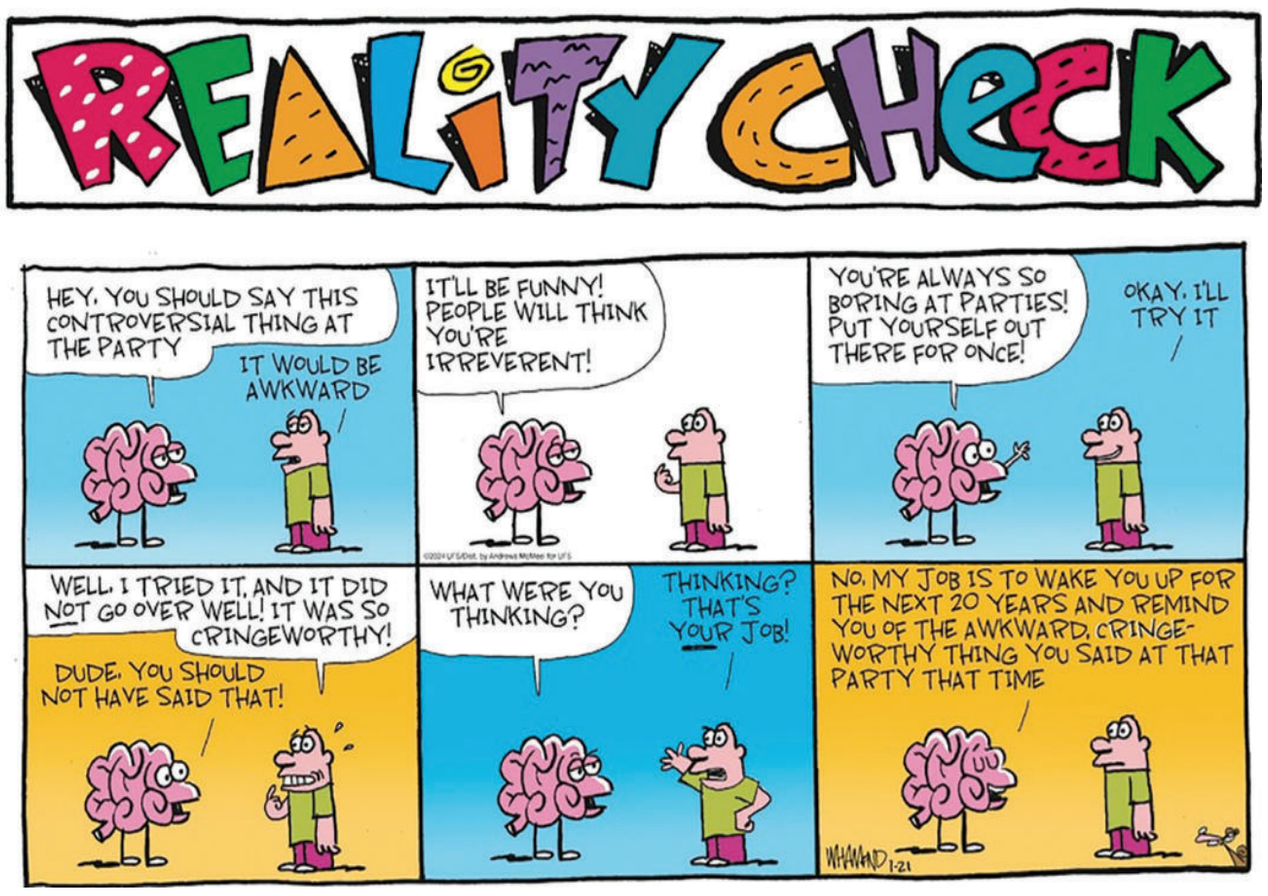
Capricorn: Hidden enemies could come out of nowhere! This might not be someone who has a full vendetta against you -- there may be a stranger who confronts you or an acquaintance who makes a negative comment.

Aquarius: You might have to put on a temporary performance. It doesn't matter if this performance is literally on a stage, or if you're trying to maintain a happy face to cheer up someone else -- going through the motions.

Pisces: To follow tradition, or to forge your own path? This question is being asked of you at this moment, where you're meant to ponder whether or not you want to follow in the footsteps of those that came before yous..

CARTOON

gocomics.com



Nepal loses first match to young Blackcaps at ICC U19 World Cup

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 21



PHOTO CREDIT:CAN

New Zealand's Snehith Reddy batting while Nepal's Uttam Magar wicketkeeping during the ICC Under-19 World Cup match in East London, South Africa, Sunday.

Nepal U19 lost its opening group match of the 15th edition of the ICC Under-19 World Cup against New Zealand's young team by 64 runs at Buffalo Park in East London, South Africa, on Sunday.

Chasing a target of 303, Nepal could only score 238 runs in the loss of nine wickets in the 50 overs the team batted. Starting with openers Deepak Bohora and Arjun Kumal, Deepak was sent back to the pavilion by Mason Clarke in the very first over for a duck. However, Arjun stayed, and Nepal had a sight to win until he was at the crease.

Hitting 12 fours and scoring 90 runs in 104 deliveries, Kumal departed as the eighth wicket of Nepal leaving the team at 176 in the 38th over. Until then, Aakash Tripathi had departed for two, Uttam Magar for a duck, Gulshan Jha for two, Dipak Bohora for 15 and Dipesh Kandel for a duck.

Captain Dev Khanal, who came in at four, and Arjun were expected to create a proper partnership in the middle order; however, Dev departed in the 16th over after scoring 36 off 34 with the help of five fours and a six.

The only other six for Nepal came from the bat of Tilak Bhandari, who entered the crease as the final wicket when Nepal was at 201 for nine. Playing all the 50 overs of the chase, Subash Bhandari (33 off 52) and Tilak (17 off 19) stayed not out and took the team to 238 runs after Aakash Chand departed as the ninth wicket after adding 14 runs.

Nepal still has two matches in the group stage against Pakistan and Afghanistan in the upcoming days at Buffalo Park. Nepal still has chances to qualify for the top six from two groups.

Mason Clarke bagged three wickets while Ewald Schreuder and Oscar Jackson claimed two each. Zac Cumming and Matt Rowe were also able to pocket one wicket each for the young Blackcaps.



Nepal's Arjun Kumal batting against New Zealand.

Snehith Reddy was ready

Winning the toss and electing to bat, New Zealand's openers Tom Jones and Luke Watson started the inning calmly. Nepal had to wait for the first powerplay to end for their partnership to end. Subash Bhandari bowled out Watson as the first wicket in the first ball of the 11th over.

Then came Snehith Reddy Devireddy and took the helm of the batting inning. Staying not out throughout the inning, banging six sixes and 11 fours in 125 deliveries, Snehith scored 147 runs.

Nepal was able to send Jones and Oliver Tewatiya back to the pavilion until the 15th over with New Zealand at 67/3. New Zealand U19 captain Oscar Jackson then joined Snehith to take the team to 224 runs in 41.5 overs as Jackson departed at 75 runs off 81 balls.

Oscar showed his class as he sent the ball above the boundary for a maximum five times. He was bowled by Aakash Tripathi. Snehith was then at 80 off 83.

The only other stable partnership with Snehith was by Alex Thompsonm, who came in at eight, as the duo scored 49 off 31.

Subash took three wickets in total while Gulshan Jha bagged two. Dipesh Kandel, Aakash and Tilak claimed one each as New Zealand ended its 50 overs at 302/8.

Koshi packed at 25, faces sixth loss; Police defeats Army

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 21

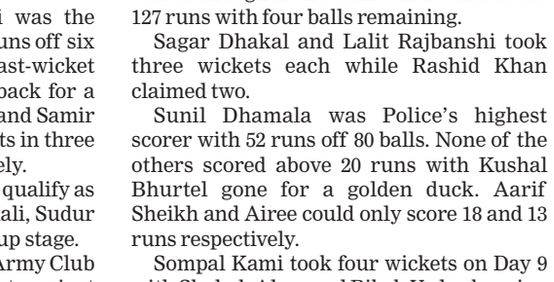


PHOTO: BIKASH/TRN

Koshi Province played its sixth match of the PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament on Sunday and lost it in a bitter manner than the previous five.

Electing to field first, Koshi was able to bundle out Gandaki at 167 runs in 48.2 overs at Mulpani International Cricket Ground.

Avyash Timsina took a six-wicket haul for Koshi bowling 9.2 overs with two maidens. Five of the top six batsmen in Gandaki's line-up – Sameer Kandel (0 off 8), Muskan Thapa (67 off 122), Krish Ayer (golden duck), Aswani Rana (6 off 9) and Amrit Gurung (4 off 12) – and the final batsmen Sandeep Parajuli were the victims of Timsina.

Muskan was the highest scorer crossing a half-century followed by Captain Bipin Khatri's 42 runs off 71 balls. Kamal Pariyar was the only other batsman for Gandaki to score in two digits with 13 runs off 28 deliveries.

Firodh Ansari, Kamal Khatri and Sonu Mandal also bagged a wicket each for Koshi.

Koshi was desperate for a win as it had tasted defeat in all five previous matches in the campaign. However, the chase ended in 15.2 overs at a score of only 25 runs with none of the batsman scoring in two digits.

Captain Bipin Khatri was great with the ball as he replied to Koshi with a six-wicket haul. In seven overs he bowled, Khatri only gave four runs with three maidens. Sandeep Parajuli took three wickets and Ankit Neupane one.

Koshi's captain Ankit Subedi was the team's highest scorer with eight runs off six balls. Opener Sonu Ansari and last-wicket batsman Hemant Rai were sent back for a golden duck with Firdosh Ansari and Samir Karki failing to open their accounts in three and five balls they faced respectively.

Koshi, with almost no chance to qualify as the top 4 teams, is yet to face Karnali, Sudur Pashchim and Lumbini in the group stage.

On the other hand, Tribhuwan Army Club was able to escape a bitter defeat against Nepal Police Club in a departmental derby at Siddhartha Cricket Ground in Rupandehi on Sunday.

Chasing a target of 141 runs by Nepal Police in a match reduced to 33 overs each due to bad weather, Army lost three wickets in 3.2 overs with the team at a score of only three runs. Top-three batsmen of Army – Imran Sheikh, Santosh Karki and Sandeep Rajali – were sent back to the pavilion for a duck.

Bhim Sharki and Kushal Malla then started a decent partnership until the 22nd over as Malla departed at 35 runs in 48 balls after getting bowled by his national team colleague Dipendra Singh Airee. Sharki was able to reach his half-century but was caught by Airee in 25.5 overs at 52 off 76. Army's captain Binod Bhandari, who came in the middle-order, also departed at 19 runs. None of the other lower-order batsmen scored enough as the team was bowled out at 127 runs with four balls remaining.

Sagar Dhakal and Lalit Rajbanshi took three wickets each while Rashid Khan claimed two.

Sunil Dhamala was Police's highest scorer with 52 runs off 80 balls. None of the others scored above 20 runs with Kushal Bhurtel gone for a golden duck. Aarif Sheikh and Airee could only score 18 and 13 runs respectively.

Sompal Kami took four wickets on Day 9 with Shahab Alam and Bibek Yadav bagging two each for Army.

SNIPPETS

Milan's Maignan walks off field

Udine (AP): AC Milan goalkeeper Mike Maignan walked off the field after being subjected to racist abuse by Udinese fans during a top-tier Italian league game on Saturday — prompting the match to be suspended briefly during the first half. Shortly after Milan had scored to take a 1-0 lead and Milan was about to take a goal kick, Maignan signaled to his teammates to stop, walked to the referee and then to the sideline.

"They made monkey noises and it's not the first time it's happened to me," the 28-year-old Maignan told DAZN. Teammates attempted to console Maignan on the sideline but then the France international took his gloves off and walked down the tunnel leading off the field.

ManU raids City for new CEO

Manchester (AP): Manchester United announced Omar Berrada as its new CEO on Saturday night after raiding rival Manchester City in a dramatic statement of intent. Man United had been looking for a successor to Richard Arnold, who left the club in November, and Berrada appears to fit the bill following his success both on and off the field with City Football Group. Berrada has been at Man City for nearly a decade, most recently as the chief football operations officer. Berrada's start date with his new club will be revealed in due course by United, who confirmed Patrick Stewart will continue as interim chief executive for the time being. "Manchester United is pleased to announce the appointment of Omar Berrada as its new CEO." United said in a statement.

Pak skipper relieved avoiding series sweep

Christchurch (AFP): The Black Caps capitulated for 92 in the face of some quality Pakistan spin bowling, having been favoured to chase down the tourists' 134-8. Pakistan lost the five-match series 4-1 but Shaheen was pleased his first stint as captain had ended on a winning note, after being outplayed through the first four games. Part-time off-spinner Iftikhar Ahmed produced career-best figures of 3-24 against a weakened New Zealand batting lineup, who scored their second-lowest T20 total on home soil. Only opener Finn Allen (22) and Glenn Phillips (26) passed 20 as Pakistan claimed the last eight wickets for 39 runs.

Dricus Du Plessis outpoints Sean Strickland for middleweight belt

AP
Toronto, Jan 21

The hostility brewing between Sean Strickland and Dricus Du Plessis finally hit its boiling point at UFC 297 on Saturday night.

The two battled through five rounds, taking the bout to the distance, but in the end, it was Du Plessis taking Strickland's middleweight belt after bloodying the former champ over his left eye and winning a split decision.

Judges Derek Cleary and Eric Colon scored the bout 48-47 in favour of Du Plessis, while Sal D'Amato had it 48-47 for Strickland. "This is history!" Du Plessis (21-2) screamed in honour of his homeland. "South Africa ... we can probably hear them from outside. That country is amazing."

It was December when Du Plessis referenced Strickland's abusive relationship with his father. Strickland let it be known that would not be tolerated, and violent recourse would result.

At UFC 296 in December, Strickland jumped over a row of seats and threw punches at Du Plessis — which both said was nowhere near a publicity stunt.

Meanwhile, Raquel Pennington (16-9-0) beat Mayra Bueno Silva (10-3-1) by unanimous decision to claim the vacant women's bantamweight championship in the co-main event. Pennington was listed as the underdog in the match.

Neil Magny (29-12-0) stopped Mike Malott (10-2-1) at the 4:45 mark of the third round of their welterweight match.

Chris Curtis (31-10-0) took a split decision over Marc-Andre Barriault (16-7-0) in their middleweight bout. Curtis took two scores of 30-27 Curtis, while Barriault won 29-28 on a third scorecard.

In the first match on the undercard, Movsar Evloev remained undefeated (17-0-0) with a unanimous decision over Arnold Allen (19-3-0). All three judges scored it 29-28. Evloev, who owns the second-longest active winning streak in the UFC featherweight division (7), ran his overall UFC win streak to eight straight.



Photo: AP
Dricus Du Plessis celebrates after defeating Sean Strickland in a middleweight title bout in Toronto early Sunday, Jan. 21, 2024.

Djokovic into Australian Open quarterfinals



AP
Melbourne, Jan. 21

Achieving yet another record at the Australian Open put Novak Djokovic in a reflective mood, revealing how he thought things might change after he'd clinched that historic 24th major title.

Djokovic played his best two sets "in a while" in a 6-0, 6-0, 6-3 demolition of Adrian Mannarino on Sunday to reach the quarterfinals at a major for the 58th time, equalling Roger Federer's Grand Slam record.

It's his 14th run to the last eight at Melbourne Park, where his conversion rate is incredible. Of the previous 13, he's gone on to win 10 Australian titles. Even with two more major titles than any man in history, he said he can't relax and just enjoy it.

"You can see it even today. I was 6-Love, 2-Love up. It was a long game, and I was like going on with discussions, heated discussions, with my box," he said. "The fire is still burning. In the quarterfinals he'll be facing No. 12-ranked Taylor Fritz, who reached the last eight in Australia for the first time with a 7-6 (3), 5-7, 6-3, 6-3 win over 2023 runner-up Stefanos Tsitsipas.

For Djokovic, it was a rare day session. He said it's no secret he prefers the 7 p.m. start but if the scoreline was any reflection of how he played in the daylight, he was content.

He dropped sets in his first two rounds and struggled with a virus but said his last two wins show "it's going in a positive direction, health-wise, tennis-wise."

No. 4 Jannik Sinner hasn't dropped a set en-route to the quarterfinals, with the Italian beating No. 15 Karen Khachanov on Sunday, nor have women's defending champion Aryna Sabalenka and U.S. Open winner Coco Gauff.

Sabalenka will next play 2021 French Open champion Barbora Krejcikova, who dropped the first set but rallied for a 4-6, 6-3, 6-2 win that ended 16-year-old Mirra Andreeva's bid to become the youngest Australian Open quarterfinalist since Martina Hingis in 1997.

No. 2-ranked Sabalenka, who won her first Slam title here last year, beat Amanada Anisimova 6-3, 6-2. Gauff, who picked up her first major at the U.S. Open in September, beat Magdalena Frech 6-1, 6-2.

WEATHER

Monday

Sunrise at 6:56 am, Sunset at 5:33 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Monday)

Partly cloudy in Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim along with the hilly regions of the rest of the provinces. Chances of light snowfall in Koshi and Gandaki's mountainous regions.

Expected Temp.: 17-19 Rain Probability: 0%

Sunday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	15.0	3.5	0.0
Dipayal	21.5	3.8	0.0
Dhangadi	16.2	6.8	0.0
Birendranagar	21.1	3.3	0.0
Nepalgunj	12.7	9.6	0.0
Jumla	12.0	-5.6	0.0
Ghorahi	19.9	5.8	0.0
Pokhara	20.0	6.5	0.0
Bhairahawa	12.5	8.8	0.0
Simara	12.6	10.0	0.0
Kathmandu	17.6	4.1	0.0
Okhaldhunga	17.7	5.2	0.0
Taplejung	14.7	3.6	0.0
Dhankuta	20.8	6.5	0.0
Biratnagar	16.7	11.0	0.0
Janakpur	16.2	10.8	0.5
Dharan	23.0	10.0	0.0*
Lumle	17.1	6.5	0.0*
Janakpur	18.8	9.4	0.0*
Jiri	16.6	0.7	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 22, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.61	Rs. 133.21
Euro	1	Rs. 144.52	Rs. 145.17
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.44	Rs. 169.20
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 152.65	Rs. 153.34
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 87.50	Rs. 87.89
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.74	Rs. 99.19
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.92	Rs. 99.37
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.95	Rs. 8.99
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.43	Rs. 18.52
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.36	Rs. 35.52
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.38	Rs. 36.54
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.73	Rs. 3.75
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.10	Rs. 36.27
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.11	Rs. 28.24
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.94	Rs. 9.98
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.67	Rs. 12.73
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.38	Rs. 19.47
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.96	Rs. 17.04
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.90	Rs. 432.85
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.75	Rs. 353.34

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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